

Something in the Water: Where Do Great Athletes Come From? (Transcript)

Listen along

Good Sport Something in the Water: Where Do Great Athletes Come From?

February 8, 2023

[00:00:00] Jody Avirgan: Bomani Jones noticed something. That's one of the best things about Bomani. He's one of the most popular sports journalists around. He watches games. He has takes. He has an HBO show. He has a podcast. We all have a podcast. But more than anything, Bomani is a noticer. I kind of picture him watching a football game on a Monday night, standing a little off to the side, arms crossed, head cocked, thinking about the plays, the players, the sport as a whole, and then he notices something about some of the players on the field, especially the wide receivers—especially the white wide receivers.

[00:00:43] Bomani Jones: It's very interesting if you note the, like, really good white wide receivers, they seem overall to have one thing in common, which is they all seem to grow up in places that are almost exclusively white, or at the very least, don't have Black people.

[00:01:01] Jody Avirgan: Now this, this is an intriguing observation. If you've watched any football over the last, oh, 40 years, you've probably noticed that most of the top wide receivers are Black, but there are the occasional white pass-catchers who break through.

[00:01:16] Bomani Jones: So take Cooper Kupp, for example.

[00:01:17] Jody Avirgan: Cooper Kupp, incredible receiver. Also? Fun name to say. Cooper Kupp. Cooper Kupp.

[00:01:24] Bomani Jones: Cooper Kupp is from somewhere in the middle of nowhere in the state of Washington, went to Eastern Washington University.

[00:01:29] Jody Avirgan: Yakima, Washington, Bomani.

[00:01:31] Bomani Jones: Yes. Yakima, Washington.

[00:01:32] Jody Avirgan: Don't even need to look up the stats. I think we—

[00:01:34] Bomani Jones: Nope, nope, nope, nope, nope. You said it all, right? Um, Jordy Nelson, remember he played for the Packers from Manhattan, Kansas.

[00:01:42] Jody Avirgan: In football, the stereotype is to see Black players as faster and more athletic, and to see white players as the brains of the operation. This racist stereotype meant that for decades there were very few Black quarterbacks. Black players would run or catch the ball. White players would be behind center. Bomani's theory kind of turns that inside out, right? Because if you've got a football team in say, Manhattan, Kansas, and all of your players are white, who's gonna play wide receiver?

Cooper Kupp, Yakima, Washington. Wes Walker and Riley Cooper from Oklahoma City, Oklahoma. Um, Garrett Crockford from Chesterfield, Minnesota. Um, Eric Decker is from Cold Spring, Minnesota. 0.2% Black.

Bomani, one of those names I just listed was made up.

[00:02:33] Bomani Jones: It was the second to last one.

[00:02:34] Jody Avirgan: Garrett Crockford does not exist.

[00:02:36] Bomani Jones: Yeah. I was like, "Huh. He must be new."

[00:02:38] Jody Avirgan: Chesterfield, Minnesota does not exist. But I was gonna, if you called me out, I was gonna tell you that he, he got 800 receiving yards in 2012 for the Titans. For all these players, the real ones, not the ones I made up, Bomani's theory checks out. Wes Walker's high school in Oklahoma City has about 900 students. Only 50 or so are Black. Not a lot. I mean, you can go online and check this out for yourself, or you can trust us and find better ways to spend your time.

[00:03:06] Bomani Jones: It's basically if we ain't got no other choice, then I guess we'll play this white dude and then when he gets good, we will tell everybody he is the greatest ever.

[00:03:17] Jody Avirgan: Really, Bomani is making an observation about opportunity and the circumstances in which someone is willing to give you that opportunity to crack open the door to success.

[00:03:28] Bomani Jones: Well, so if you talk about opportunity, the example that jumps out to me is Hunter Renfrow. Hunter Renfrow plays wide receiver for the, uh, Las Vegas Raiders.

[00:03:38] Jody Avirgan: Hunter Renfrow is another famous white wide receiver. He played college ball at Clemson and guess what? The coach there is Dabo Swinney, who himself was a white wide receiver. Can you hear the door of opportunity squeaking open?

[00:03:54] Bomani Jones: Dabo's still out here with white dudes playing linebacker, and a dude like Hunter Renfro playing wide receiver because Dabo is looking at that dude through a different lens and is like, "Yo, people don't give this guy an opportunity."

But it is, I think, again, about opportunity. It's about people looking at these guys and saying, not even "he can do this", "Well, let's just see if he can." And then when they do, he's your best wide receiver. You ride that thing out.

[00:04:18] Jody Avirgan: Yeah. Yeah, it's about time, you know, white guys start looking out for each other.

[00:04:23] Bomani Jones: Yes, yes. But yo, but this is actually an interesting case where I do firmly believe that white dudes are underrated, because the assumption walking in the door is that they can't do it. And then when you see them do it, it's like people think it must be a trick.

[00:04:39] Jody Avirgan: I mean, it sort of is a trick in the sense of, here's one simple trick: try to evaluate someone based on their actual potential rather than what you assume their potential to be.

And that's what I find so compelling about Bomani's observation because it suggests that there is something really wrong with the way that we evaluate talent, which in turn has some pretty big implications for the way we dole out opportunities. If we recognize that all these other forces play a role in success, maybe we then have to rethink how we nurture talent and where we look for it in the first place. Looking at a talented player, someone who made it, you have to ask: what was it about that particular situation that allowed them to flourish?

[00:05:22] Bomani Jones: They did a documentary about it called Something in the Water.

[00:05:24] Jody Avirgan: Yeah.

[00:05:24] Bomani Jones: And I still don't think it really came down to it, you know, to an actual answer because the title of it is Something in the Water.

[00:05:29] Jody Avirgan: Yeah!

[00:05:30] Bomani Jones: Which is you throw out there when you have no idea why it is that this happens.

[00:05:33] Jody Avirgan: Uh, we are, okay, we're gonna strike, uh, "Something In the Water" off the name of, uh, possible names for this episode.

[BREAK]

[00:05:47] Jody Avirgan: This is Good Sport from the TED Audio Collective. My name is Jody Avirgan. Today's episode: Talent, Nurture, and Nature. Eh, that's not very good. Let's go with "Open Door, Closed Door". Oh, that name kind of sucks too. You know what? Screw it. We're calling it "Something in the Water". You don't control us, Bomani Jones.

[BREAK]

[00:06:26] Jody Avirgan: This is the part of the first episode of a new podcast series where I tell you who I am and what we're up to. My name's Jody. I've reported on politics, culture,

and sports for a long time. Even better, when all of those combine. I hosted a podcast called 30 For 30. I've done stories about the NBA and Olympics and World Cup Soccer.

I'd like to think I'm wired a little bit like Bomani Jones: arms crossed, head cocked. Curious about a small question in sports that might get at a bigger point about the world. Because for me, every big life lesson I've learned has come through sports: how to channel my competitive fire, how to be a supportive teammate or boss or partner. How to focus on what I can control and try to let go of what I can't.

I've learned all of that by playing sports. I'm not saying it's the only place you can learn those lessons. Just happens to be where I have. And now, this is the part of the first episode of the new podcast series where I tell you that the sport that most taught me all of this is ultimate Frisbee.

For some of you, you'll be like, "Okay, I get it. Ultimate. Real sport. Let's keep it moving."

Some of you may be reaching for your podcast app to find a different show to listen to. What can I say? That was my sport. I played in college and club and even pro for a couple years. I was on SportsCenter. It was serious for me, the only thing that mattered for, like, two decades.

That's where I learned my lessons, including, I should say, lessons about talent and opportunity. So yeah, from time to time, in future episodes, there will be some ultimate Frisbee content. I'll win you over. You'll keep listening.

Welcome to our first episode: Something in the Water. Yeah, that works. Bomani Jones is here and we're asking the question, what does it take for someone talented to get a real shot?

[00:08:18] Bomani Jones: Baseline talent has to be there, and then we go from there. And yes, after that point, we are talking about nurturing; we are talking about belief.

[00:08:29] Jody Avirgan: Yeah.

[00:08:30] Bomani Jones: We are talking about affirming within people, "this is something that you can do and I am going to train you to do this excellently because you can, in fact, be excellent at this."

[00:08:40] Jody Avirgan: And, and the sort of corollary to giving someone opportunity is also giving someone multiple chances. And so often I feel like it comes down to the, how short is the leash for screwing up.

[00:08:53] Bomani Jones: Yes.

[00:08:53] Jody Avirgan: You know, and that's often what it takes. It takes faith, you know, in the, in the real deepest way.

The point is, you do need more than pure talent to get to the top. You need all those doors being held open for you on your path. All those chances to prove yourself worthy. All the times someone leaned in close, looked you in the eye, and said, "It could be you." You need—let's coin a phrase here—you need an opportunity pipeline.

[00:09:22] Bomani Jones: Now, if I were to connect that to my own life... I am a graduate of a historically black college, Clark College, and one thing that you learn and figure out very quickly going to an HBCU is if you look at the stats of, like, who goes to medical school and who goes to graduate school, like studying for PhDs, among Black people, the sample is disproportionately HBCU grads.

And so what I knew from my own experience at the HBCU was what I was more likely to receive at the HBCU was the attention that comes from somebody who believes that you're special. If the sample is then all Black people, then a lot of the head trash that comes in about what Black people are and what Black people are not, you kind of have to throw it out, right?

Like, the control is set for race. Everybody there is the same. You're gonna have a harder time bringing that stuff in, saying this person isn't this, this person isn't that. 'Cause you're gonna see them all together, and those who are, are gonna rise without, you know, all these things that come in and mess up your mind in the process.

[00:10:26] Jody Avirgan: At Bomani's College, there was an ecosystem in place that set people up to succeed over and over. There's an equivalent to that in sports. Hotbeds: pockets of the country that have found a way to produce a particular kind of great athlete over and over, to the point where you almost do have to wonder, man, could there just be something in the water?

These are places like the area around Belle Glade, Florida, also known as Muck City. Home to brilliant, wide receiver after brilliant wide receiver, including Santonio Holmes and Anquan Boldin. That's one hotbed. Or think about swimmers from the Bay Area or sprinters from Jamaica. Baseball players from the Dominican Republic. Hotbeds are opportunity pipelines.

[00:11:10] Bomani Jones: I mean, the big one to me is basketball in Kinston, North Carolina.

[00:11:14] Jody Avirgan: Uh-huh.

[00:11:14] Bomani Jones: Um, which is the hometown of Jerry Stackhouse, uh, Cedric Maxwell, Andrew Wiggins' father Mitchell, uh, Reggie Bullock, and Kinston, I wanna say, is a population of 20,000 people. I forget what the exorbitant odds are from most schools in terms of producing players who go to the NBA, but it's one in however many thousands. At Kinston High School, it is an absurdly high rate. That one hugely fascinates me.

[00:11:44] Jody Avirgan: He's right. The odds of making the league, if you're not from Kinston, North Carolina, are like 3 in 10,000. In Kinston, it's about 1 out of 50. Incredible.

There are legends about what makes a lot of these hotbeds work. In the part of Florida they call Muck City, which produces all those NFL receivers, people talk about how during the late summer harvest season, kids chase rabbits in the local sugar cane fields. That's how they get so fast and agile and eventually turn into great football players.

Those are all "something in the water" explanations, but there actually are a number of ingredients that seem to make an opportunity pipeline work. Maybe there's a formula of sorts. So, grab a pencil. Let's make a list. You, me, Bomani. One ingredient: intense competition. Take a place like New York City basketball in the eighties and nineties, a hotbed of generationally talented point guards.

[00:12:44] Bomani Jones: I contend that the advantage that New York basketball players had over everybody else is how easy it was to get a game against great players, right? Like you were a subway ride away from a—if you are a Kenny Anderson, New York legend coming up, you can go play against anybody, even if you're in Queens, right? It might take you a while on the train to get to where you going, but you could go play against anybody and sharpen your skills in a way that is far more difficult if you're from a small town.

[00:13:11] Jody Avirgan: Yeah.

[00:13:11] Bomani Jones: Or far more difficult, even if you're from a mid-sized city.

[00:13:14] Jody Avirgan: Okay, competition is on the list. Another factor, coaching. You hear stories about certain coaches who move from one part of the country to another, and then all of a sudden all the great players, the quarterbacks, the hockey goalies, whatever, they're all coming from that area now. So good coaching, a competitive cohort, and I mean, let's be honest, money has to be on the list. People pour massive resources into things like youth football in Texas.

[00:13:37] Bomani Jones: Texas produces overdeveloped football prospects, like all the money has been put into infrastructure and everything else.

[00:13:44] Jody Avirgan: Going back to the Muck City example, local role models seem really important. You know, you're a rising eighth grader, and all of a sudden you look up and there's Anquan Boldin, and Santonio Holmes playing in the Super Bowl, and they're from your little town of 20,000 people. And you're like, "That could be me," you know?

[00:14:00] Bomani Jones: Yeah. And there're people coming back and they're saying, "Yeah, it can be you." And the person coming back might be Anquan Boldin.

[00:14:05] Jody Avirgan: Right. Yeah.

So our hotbed formula, coaching, competition, cash, inspiration, and what the hell? Let's throw chasing rabbits into the mix as well.

[BREAK]

[00:14:28] Jody Avirgan: Bomani and I have some ideas about what makes a hotbed, but we're just two dudes with a microphone and itchy brains. To really answer this question of what makes a talent hotbed tick, we went where one always goes for answers to life's most vexing questions: a strip mall in Milpitas, California. Walk with me into a squat, boxy building that could very well have been a car dealership not that many years ago, and you'll find yourself staring at a row of photos. Seven table tennis Olympians.

[00:14:58] Rajul Sheth: Okay, so this is like our kind of a normal lobby area where we have all of our displays of our Olympians. You, you see Olympians. So anyone comes in the building, a new person, when they see this professional table tennis Olympians and uh, National team member training. And they are impressed.

[00:15:15] Jody Avirgan: Rajul Sheth runs the table tennis program here at the India Community Center in Milpitas, and this is his wall of fame, pictures of table tennis greats. All of them trained just down this echoey hallway. Let's follow Rajul there into a massive gymnasium about the size of three basketball courts. Row after row of kids playing table tennis.

[INDISTINCT CHATTER]

[00:15:39] Coach: Five, six. Very nice.

[00:15:43] Jody Avirgan: At 11:00 AM on a Tuesday, over a hundred kids are playing around dozens of ping pong tables and Rajul, I promise that's the only time I call it ping pong. The kids are stabbing at the ball, serving, rallying while their coaches look on, calling out encouragement and advice.

[00:15:57] Coach: One more. Slow, slow, slow. More rallies.

[00:16:01] Jody Avirgan: Two advanced players face off in one corner of the room, dancing around their table, the ball blurring between them. This is what we came here to see: the inner workings of a bonafide hotbed. A place that has sent at least three players to every Olympics since London a decade ago. And what's most impressive about it is that 15 years ago, when it came to table tennis, Milpitas wasn't even on the map. Rajul Sheth put it there as a coach and an administrator, but it's worth noting, he's also a really good player.

[00:16:37] Rajul Sheth: So my style playing table tennis is considered to be, uh, kind of a defense player. I used to block the ball, so I never used to attack too much. I used to make lot of rallies and, uh, with the opportunity for my opponent to make a mistake, you know, that's how I used to play.

[00:16:55] Jody Avirgan: Is that reflective of your personality in any sort of way?

[00:17:00] Rajul Sheth: Uh, yes, that's what it is. You know, to play that kind of a game, you need to have a lot of patience.

[00:17:06] Jody Avirgan: And to be a coach, you need to have a lot of patience.

[00:17:09] Rajul Sheth: A lot of patience. Yeah. So that helps. Yeah. You're absolutely right.

[00:17:10] Jody Avirgan: Rajul was born in Badora, a city on India's west coast. In India, table tennis is huge. You know that thing earlier where I had to justify my obsession with ultimate Frisbee to you? No one needs to do that with table tennis in India; its top players are regular contenders for Olympic medals against some of the true giants of the sport, China and Japan. Rajul was on the Indian National Circuit for 14 years.

[00:17:38] Rajul Sheth: In India, uh, you have a lot of advantage and benefits by playing sports of table tennis. Like in America, if you are good at basketball or you know, some, uh, mainstream sports... At, uh, age of 18, I got a government job because of table tennis, and those kind of a jobs in India, uh, helps you to play more. So basically you don't go for work, you just play table tennis two times and you got, you're paid for it.

[00:18:03] Jody Avirgan: But in 2002, despite a life in which part of his job was to play table tennis twice a day, Rajul decided to leave the sport, leave India, and make a new start in California. He wanted to work on a mechanical engineering degree.

[00:18:17] Rajul Sheth: So me and my wife, we both came to USA and uh, after coming here, we realized that at that time, economy was very bad and we realized that practically, it's not possible for both of us to go to school. So my wife started doing her master's and I started working.

[00:18:39] Jody Avirgan: Rajul put in 80-hour work weeks working retail in the day and pumping gas at night. It was a grueling schedule, and he found himself reminiscing about all those years on the table tennis circuit. Perhaps thinking to himself, you know, "There was a time not that long ago when part of my job was to play table tennis twice a day." And then one night, randomly, he saw a guy at the gas station who had some table tennis gear. They struck up a conversation, and eventually the guy agreed to take Rajul to a local tournament.

[00:19:12] Rajul Sheth: And when I went there, I saw some, uh, players training there and, uh, one or two players training there were on a US Junior National team. And, uh, I just went there with my old paddle, and I just played a little bit with those Junior National team members. And, uh, you know, I found out that I'm, I'm too good for US table tennis, you know, label and, uh, all of a sudden, I had lot of kids and parents approaching me that, you know, are you coaching table tennis anywhere?

[00:19:48] Jody Avirgan: So Rajul starts teaching, gets himself a part-time coaching job at the India Community Center in Milpitas. At first, the ICC has just a couple tables, a few kids here and there, but within six months, the program doubled in size: 30 players training regularly with Rajul.

Not long after that, they start going to tournaments and winning. All those Olympians on the wall, they came from Rajul's program at the ICC. It's also produced dozens of National team members. Last year they took home 56 medals at Nationals. This is a hotbed, so how does it work?

[00:20:28] Rajul Sheth: Lot of people, even cricket or uh, uh, lot of Indian sports people, they come and try to follow the same formula, which I follow. And, uh, even in East Coast and everywhere, people come to reach out to me, and how did you do it? And I just give my formula to all of them.

[00:20:42] Jody Avirgan: So, what's the formula? Grab a pencil. Let's make a list. You, me, Rajul.

One ingredient, same as on the list that Bomani and I made: coaching. Rajul employs a top coaching staff, people who played professionally overseas.

[00:21:03] Rajul Sheth: We started hiring, you know, coaches from India and China, uh, and in 2012, I think we got some coach from Europe as well. Uh, some senior coaches here, and I think they helped us a lot.

[00:21:16] Jody Avirgan: He recruits them to the US, helps get them places to live and steady work, and eventually, hopefully, green cards. Along with the coaches, Rajul also imports players who function like sparring partners for his students—competition. He runs leagues where top players from around the Bay Area can face off every weekend. They hone their skills, learn how to compete, push each other, kind of like the New York City basketball vibe that Bomani mentioned.

[00:21:42] Rajul Sheth: So that is very important probably where we identify, you know, who is strong mentally, who is progressing, uh, consistently, who is doing what.

[00:21:52] Jody Avirgan: And probably the most important part of the formula for Rajul: volume, bringing in as many kids as possible and giving them all the chance to excel.

[00:22:01] Rajul Sheth: You know, this is what you do. Get the volume, give the quality.

[00:22:05] Jody Avirgan: To get the volume, he uses another key ingredient to the formula: marketing. Rajul markets the program like hell, handing out literally thousands of brochures to local school kids every year. The ICC offers other programs like Tae Kwon Do and dance, but then he adds free table tennis lessons to the package. He started a summer camp to bring hundreds of new kids into the building every year. Of course, table tennis is part of the summer camp. Rajul will make anything into an opportunity to bring a new kid to the program. He will even crash your local farmer's market.

[00:22:40] Rajul Sheth: So every Sunday, there was a farmer's market in Milpitas where there were a lot of people used to come there. We used to rent a booth there. Put a ping pong table there and a coach there, and few paddles, and anyone, you know, walking there, "Can you try? You want to try a little bit?" And then we used to try to promote that if you want to play more, there is a place here in Milpitas.

[00:23:02] Jody Avirgan: Did any Olympians come from the farmer's market?

[00:23:04] Rajul Sheth: Uh, not, no. No. Not, no Olympians came from farmer's market, but at least we got lot of visibility, and lot of, uh, recreational kids came from there.

[00:23:14] Jody Avirgan: Rajul says all of this, whether or not it leads directly to a superstar, is crucial because it generates the volume.

[00:23:21] Rajul Sheth: So our goal is to get volume for table tennis because when I see, uh, entire summer camp, I may end up getting around, uh, 400 kids, you know, introduced to the table tennis. Out of those 400, maybe 50%, 200 kids will continue after camps are over. After those 200 kids, again, we may end up having, say, only 50 kids, little talented, you know. So then from that 400, we came back to 50. Then out of these 50 little talented, maybe we narrow down to another 8 to 10 kids who has that quality to become a, you know, Olympian or a National team member. And then we start working with those 8 or 10 kids very, uh, specific way and end up getting one or two Olympians out of it.

[00:24:12] Jody Avirgan: And I love that, that math, I mean, it almost sounds, and I don't think you're using it as a euphemism, it sounds like you've sort of come up with a formula, right? It's 400 to 100 to 50, to eight to one, and I think this gets at something that I'm just so curious about because I think when people think about finding talent, they think about, "Oh, it's just the one, and you find the one and they pop out and you just have to pluck them." But you're sort of really playing it like a volume game, like a numbers game.

[00:24:41] Rajul Sheth: Yeah. If you don't play volume, it's very hard to find, uh, you know, consistent tell. Okay, one-off you can find by luck or you know, from small volume. But if you want to hit, like for example, 2012, uh, that was the first time we produced three Olympians. And then we maintained that. In 2016 we had four Olympians. 2020, we had four Olympians. If you want to be a consistently, you know, produce, uh, National team members and, uh, Olympians, uh, volume is very important.

[00:25:16] Jody Avirgan: As Bomani pointed out earlier, a big part of making an opportunity pipeline is keeping those doors open for as many people as possible, as long as possible, and then seeing who walks through.

Oh, yeah, on our hotbeds list, funding: pretty critical too. Between rent for the Milpitas facilities, salaries for the staff, sponsorships for their most promising players, Rajul's program now costs well over a million dollars a year, but the more successful the program is, the more willing people are to help out, and the more he can sponsor kids who have promise but may not have resources.

[00:25:55] Rajul Sheth: We used to raise like, you know, a hundred thousand average every year to sponsor talented kids. And you know, we have to pay the rent, we have to pay salary to our coaches. So, you know, lucky again, we have a lot of people, you know, ready to support us.

[00:26:11] Jody Avirgan: And I'll just say: along with the training and coaches and competition and funding, one of the key things Rajul is doing here, one of the most important is building community, in the truest sense. He takes care of his coaches. He provides other activities for athletes. He invests in his players' daily life. Sure, he's trying to find top players, but he's also trying to make his project vital to the families in Milpitas. It's a community center after all.

So, who ends up with their picture on that wall at the ICC? Take for example, Lily Zhang, one of the most successful American table tennis players and a product of the ICC.

[00:26:52] Rajul Sheth: Lilly ended up playing 2012 Olympics. She ended up playing 2016 Olympics. Uh, she ended up playing 2020 Olympics.

[00:27:02] Jody Avirgan: That's in large part because Lilly got put into the formula.

[00:27:05] Rajul Sheth: She got opportunity, you know, because we got some high-level players and coaches for her from India and China. Funding, we sponsored her entire training for kind of a free. Plus, even in uh, 2012 to encourage them to play more table tennis, we even came up with a stipend system for them.

[00:27:30] Jody Avirgan: Rajul saw the talent Lily had and did everything he could to make the system work for her.

[00:27:36] Rajul Sheth: The problem in 2010, 12 or 14, you know, parents, they didn't wanted their kids to play more. You know, they, they didn't see much benefit in sports at that time. And when we were telling that, you know, your kid has a chance to play Olympics, they didn't believe us. So keep them motivated to play, we made entire training free for Lily.

[00:27:58] Jody Avirgan: So you can see the pipeline worked for Lily Zhang, but it wasn't just the formula. Lily had more: something else worth considering as we think about opportunity. She had, and I'm sorry to be cliché here, but Lily had it: that cluster of qualities that makes someone great at a particular sport, and Rajul spotted it in her.

[00:28:20] Rajul Sheth: The first thing I noticed in her is her mental game. She was very strong.

You know, sometimes you go on a floor, you have too much pressure on you. You know, people watching your matches or tournament. Even if you tell them to do something, when the, the rally starts, they are not able to, you know, follow your instructions. So at a young age, you know, try to follow all those things. You know, whatever you tell them, they just follow that. You know right away. Not everyone can adopt that.

[00:28:51] Jody Avirgan: I'm fascinated by the IT factor. Of course, all the players that make it to the end of a pipeline from Milpitas or Kinston or wherever, they are really good, but we don't gravitate towards the really good, we look for the great, the singular.

I might be obsessed with that distinction because I was really good. But I don't think I was great, and there have been times when that's eaten me up. It might be something that eats Rajul up as well. Towards the end of our conversation with him, he brought up another player, he's worked with a ton, maybe even more than Lily Zhang: his own son, Ved.

[00:29:30] Rajul Sheth: So when I say not everyone can adopt it, I can just give example of my son as well. Now, when I talk about my own son, I still feel that he's not talented. He's, uh, very hardworking, very hardworking, but not talented.

[00:29:49] Jody Avirgan: Ved is really good, but he's not checking every box. He may not be the one.

And you can make that assessment with a lot of different, you know, with different kids as you've said. Was it particularly hard to see that with your own son?

[00:30:06] Rajul Sheth: Yeah. Yeah. It's, you know, so when I, when it comes to my son, it's not... I, I tried my best, you know, to teach him. But see, it depends on each and every kids, you know. How much they can adopt that. Now he has some other plus qualities. He's very hardworking. So he is hardworking. He has a very good mental game. He is kind of, uh, diverting all his time to table tennis. He listens to the coach, everything. But now he miss something. You know, the talent.

You have a very high level, a professional Olympian or a Olympic metal winner, uh, kind of player. You have to have everything in them.

[00:30:58] Jody Avirgan: So yes, not every kid is going to be Lily Zhang. Well, what hotbeds demonstrate is that if you give every kid a chance, if you get your own assumptions out of the way and give them the resources and the training and give them your faith, if you keep sticking your foot in the door of opportunity before it fully shuts, you never know.

Not everyone can become a great athlete, but a great athlete can come from anywhere. Yes, I just stole that line from the final monologue in Pixar's Ratatouille. Instead of listening to this whole episode, I probably should have just told you to go watch Ratatouille.

So that's it for the first episode of our new podcast, Good Sport. But if you're still listening, I should tell you that this is the part where I point out that what we just did, that's pretty much what we'll be getting up to all season. Each episode of this series will explore a phenomenon from the world of sports.

What makes a hotbed? Why stadium deals go wrong so often. How sports debate shows got so out of control. What comes next for athletes and us when our bodies age and our careers are over? All of these, I think, help us understand larger forces in the world we live in. From politics, to relationships, to culture and media and more, because it's my argument to you that when we look at the larger world through the lens of sports, maybe we can see it more clearly.

So this season, we'll carry that lens of sports around. Sometimes we'll turn the lens on ourselves, make it into kind of a mirror. Sometimes we'll use it as a magnifying glass and hunch over to examine something small but fascinating. Sometimes we'll use that lens as a telescope, a way of looking at something distant, but full of promise. Sometimes we'll take that lens metaphor and stretch it to the point where you're not really sure what the hell Jody is talking about anymore. All that and more this season on Good Sport. Let's do it. Go Sixers.

Up next on Good Sport, I channel my inner sports debate bro.

...And then you have the single most iconic moment in NBA history. Alan Iverson stepping over Tyronn Lue.

[00:33:23] Katie Nolan: I mean, and you're not wrong.

[00:33:24] Jody Avirgan: Incredible.

[00:33:25] Katie Nolan: It's an iconic moment.

[00:33:27] Jody Avirgan: And why the way we argue about sports seems to be the way we argue about everything.

Good Sport is brought to you by the TED Audio Collective. It's hosted by me, Jody Avirgan. This show is produced by TED. This episode was written and produced by Isabel Carter. Our team includes Camille Peterson, Poncie Rutsch, Sarah Nics, Jimmy Gutierrez, Michelle Quint, BanBan Cheng, and Roxanne Hai Lash. Jake Gorski is our sound designer and mix engineer.

Fact-checking by Julia Dickerson. Thanks to Mumble Media's, Jayme Catsouphe, who was our eyes and ears on the ground in Milpitas. Special thanks to John Cox, Keith Rumer, and Katie Clark, and very special thanks to Bomani Jones. Make sure to check out Game Theory on HBO for more of his excellent observations.

We'll be back soon with more Good Sport. Be sure to follow the show in your favorite podcast app so you get every episode delivered straight to your device, and leave us a review. We love hearing from our listeners. See you soon.

Pardon the Interruption... But Did Sports Debate Shows Change the World? (Transcript)
Listen along

Good Sport Pardon the Interruption... But Did Sports Debate Shows Change the World?
February 15, 2023

[00:00:07] Jody Avirgan: Katie, if I'm doing this, what should my body language be?

[00:00:12] Katie Nolan: Aggressive, confident, engaging. Um, you, you wanna talk with your hands a lot.

[00:00:19] Jody Avirgan: I called up my friend Katie Nolan recently to ask her to teach me how to fight.

[00:00:24] Katie Nolan: If you're in the hotspot, if your, if your opponent is talking or your co-host or whatever, you can be an active listener by making faces at them.

[00:00:32] Jody Avirgan: Katie is a sports commentator. She worked at Fox Sports and ESPN for many years. That's where we got to know each other, when I was at ESPN, too. Actually, when she signed onto the call, she was joining from an ESPN company laptop that she never returned.

[00:00:48] Katie Nolan: They never asked for it, so it's... I know.

[00:00:51] Jody Avirgan: Wow. They're still, they're still like tracking every one of your, uh, keystrokes.

[00:00:53] Katie Nolan: Yeah, probably. It's why I don't do anything real shady on here.

[00:00:55] Jody Avirgan: And if we're confessing this microphone I'm using, it was also for my time at ESPN, but I digress. We are here to talk about arguing. There's a lot of arguing at ESPN, on ESPN. It's all around sports media. I'm talking about the sports debate guy. It's almost always a guy, the hot-take artist, and there's kind of a formula to the way that this guy fights.

[00:01:22] Katie Nolan: As the speaker, while giving a hot take, you certainly don't want anything that indicates you aren't a hundred percent behind what it is that you're saying. You can't be shaky when you're take-y. That's good to remember.

[00:01:33] Jody Avirgan: Did you just make that up?

[00:01:36] Katie Nolan: Yeah. It just fell right out of my mouth and I'm very sorry.

[00:01:38] Jody Avirgan: I'm, I couldn't be more pleased.

You can't be shaky when you're take-y. That should be the tagline for all these guys. You can find them on shows like Undisputed with Skip Bayless and Shannon Sharpe, Around the

Horn, Get Up, and of course, First Take with Stephen A. Smith. I mean, there's a million of them sprinkled throughout sports media.

They've come to dominate the afternoon cable lineup, not to mention talk radio. And people tune in in droves. These programs get huge ratings. The hosts have big followings. Clips go viral. Here's the basic format. Two or more hosts share the screen for an hour or so of uninterrupted sports argument.

They're shouting. There's gesticulating. People dunk on each other. They stand up in disbelief and pace around the set to show their outrage. Sometimes, there's even name-calling. Yes, it's over the top, but it's also incredibly compelling. A pure distillation of modern debate. I'm right, you're an idiot.

[00:02:41] Katie Nolan: And I think a, a lot of those shows run on antagonism, but also character. It's almost like they make an avatar of a person, and then that person's job is to continue to reaffirm everything about that avatar. So, I think a lot of it is even when two hosts agree with each other that sit across from each other, they still get three minutes to talk uninterrupted. And so they have to kind of find nuance within their take to show that it's different from the take you just heard. But also, there are things they disagree with about the take you just heard. Even if they didn't.

[00:03:21] Jody Avirgan: So, yeah, maybe you can tell I'm a little wary of these shows. I do think they're kind of gross on some level, but there's also something about them that's just so seductive, and occasionally, watching one of these shout-bro shows, I've wondered: Do I have this in me? Could I join the ranks of the debate show greats? I have friends who've made the jump and landed some pretty sweet contracts. I've put in my time in sports media. I know how this game works. I do have opinions, and you know, when I worked at ESPN making the 30 For 30 podcast, I even technically had the same title as Stephen A. Smith. I swear to God, if you looked at the org chart, we were both just listed as "Commentator". Our salaries were very different.

[MUSIC BREAK]

[00:04:11] Jody Avirgan: This is Good Sport from the TED Audio Collective. My name is Jody Avirgan. Today: a look at how we argue about sports and more, and an experiment. With the help of Katie Nolan, I'm going full Stephen A.

[00:04:26] Katie Nolan: Let's do this.

[BREAK]

[00:04:42] Jody Avirgan: We're with my coach, Katie Nolan. Point of interest, she actually got her start in the world of sports, not as a commentator, but as a competitor, an elite competitor. Folks, she insisted we mentioned this.

[00:04:56] Katie Nolan: You want me to talk about my Junior Olympic gold medal in rhythmic gymnastics?

[00:05:00] Jody Avirgan: Yes.

[00:05:00] Katie Nolan: I usually don't start with that 'cause I don't like to intimidate people. You know, I'm a real salt-of-the-earth type of gal. I want people to know I'm one of them. But yes, I did. I did win multiple Junior Olympic medals, one or two of which were gold in the sport of rhythmic gymnastics.

[00:05:16] Jody Avirgan: For some reason, Katie had to eventually give up her rhythmic gymnastic dreams and get a real job, which brings us to her sports talk career. Her resume as a commentator is pretty amazing. She did her time at ESPN. She covered the Olympics for NBC. She had a web series for Fox Sports 1. Most recently, she's co-hosted Friday night baseball on Apple TV+. Throughout, she's always been super smart and engaging and never gone full hot-take artist.

But if I'm like five degrees removed from that world, Katie has stared directly into the abyss and laughed. Someone recently described her to me as the number one line stepper in all of sports. Perfectly willing to tell it like it is and poke fun. One of my favorite things she ever did was a segment where she parodied sports argument by debating herself.

[00:06:07] Katie Nolan: So it's like, I don't have a co-host, but we're in sports TV, and I know you guys like to hear arguments, so I'm going to play both sides. And I wouldn't know the topic until the moment of, which was the twist. So that was what made it hard. But I would switch at the ring of a bell to arguing against myself. And for me, it was more like to kind of show that anyone can take any side of an argument.

[00:06:26] Jody Avirgan: So, who better to teach me about sports arguments?

So far, I've got never waver; turn your opponent into an avatar and debate that, not the real person; body language, over the top. It kind of sounds like a lesson in being a used car salesman or a con man or something. Should I be wearing cheap cologne?

What kind of prep do I need to do?

[00:06:48] Katie Nolan: Uh, minimal. I would say treetops. You need to hear what other people are saying about the story more than you need to know the story.

[00:06:57] Jody Avirgan: How much does your actual argument matter when it comes to facts and statistics?

[00:07:02] Katie Nolan: A famous saying: Numbers never lie. Was also the name of a show for a while. Numbers never lie. The thing is you can pick the numbers that tell the story you wanna tell, and you can ignore the numbers that really don't serve your point. That's gonna be up to your co-host then to bring those numbers and show you those receipts and be like, "What about this and this and this?" Let them worry about that.

Just pick the numbers that tell the story you wanna say and then memorize those. Or if you're me, write them on a post-it note and put 'em right next to your camera sSo that you can read them, 'cause numbers are in and outta your brain.

[00:07:34] Jody Avirgan: Should you actually listen to and engage with the argument the person sitting across from you is making?

[00:07:39] Katie Nolan: I think a lot of the times, you're listening in little spurts. You're listening to remember the things you know you can dunk on later. You're listening to, to laugh at them about something, but you're not really, like, considering their argument the way you would if you were having an argument with a person in real life. You're just kind of letting them get it out. Holding onto a few things you can use against them for your rebuttal.

[00:08:03] Jody Avirgan: What do you do if you're cornered?

[00:08:04] Katie Nolan: Change the subject. Find a way to change the subject. Do something silly. You could, you know, if it's, if you're really stuck, just take a word and say it loudly three times in a row. So, preposterous, preposterous, preposterous!

Now you've bought yourself time and you'll know where to turn. It's also given space between the thing the person said that backed you into a corner and the next thing you're gonna say, and in that space, plenty of people watching TV have already forgotten what happened.

So now you can just kind of start talking about something else, and no one's gonna notice as long as you're passionate, you're turning the emotion up a little bit more than you were before, 'cause now you really gotta sell it, and you're throwing in a couple more numbers to back up whatever this other thing is that you're saying.

[00:08:50] Jody Avirgan: I'll just say: everything that Katie is saying totally checks out. Turn on your TV or flip to your local sports talk radio station. This is what's really going on.

Stephen A. really does say “preposterous, preposterous, preposterous”, like once per show, things of that nature. One final question for Katie before I give it a shot.

What does winning look like?

[00:09:14] Katie Nolan: Oh, um, ratings, good ratings, I think. Um, winning an argument isn't necessarily about being correct or being crowned the winner. It's “Did people tune out when I was talking or did our ratings go up?”

[00:09:34] Jody Avirgan: So, now I've been trained, or it feels more like untrained since most of the tips are like, “Don't prep and cherry-pick numbers and don't listen to the other person.” Regardless, it's time for the final exam.

So look, let's say I wanted to have a hot take.

[00:09:49] Katie Nolan: Ooh, I'm so ready. Okay.

[00:09:50] Jody Avirgan: Would you help me kind of craft it and, and strategize?

[00:09:53] Katie Nolan: Yes, a hundred percent. Okay. I appreciate it.

[00:09:54] Jody Avirgan: So my take would be something like “The Allen Iverson's 2001 post-season was the greatest run in NBA history.” Maybe one of the greatest runs in NBA history.

[00:10:05] Katie Nolan: Okay, so what? Give me three facts to support it.

[00:10:12] Jody Avirgan: Well, for one, look at his supporting cast: Theo Ratliff, Eric Snow, George Lynch, and Tyrone Hill were starting forwards on that team. I mean, he had no, no help whatsoever, and he marched his way through the post-season. Um, you know, they did end up losing to the Lakers. Four to one maybe. I don't know, maybe I shouldn't bring that up.

[00:10:31] Katie Nolan: That's probably not, not number two at least. That's not your number two supporting point, is that it didn't end well.

[00:10:36] Jody Avirgan: I remember, uh, watching that series, um, probably the greatest month of my life, if I'm being honest. Um, and uh, there was a graphic up on the screen that showed all of the injuries that Allen Iverson was dealing with. He was just in—riddled with injury, and was still fighting through it. So, you know, for someone, small and fighting through injury and carrying the team on his back.

And then you have the single most, see, I'm starting to even embrace it. You fired me up. The single most—I would never say something like that—

[00:11:03] Katie Nolan: Single most.

[00:11:04] Jody Avirgan: The single most iconic moment in NBA history. Allen Iverson stepping over Tyrone Lue. Incredible.

[00:11:10] Katie Nolan: I mean, and you're not wrong. It's an iconic moment. And then you can, even, if you're feeling really confident, you can challenge someone to name another, because on the spot it's gonna be very hard for them to do. And then in the couple seconds it takes them to think of it, you'll be saying something else and we will be on to the next.

[00:11:23] Jody Avirgan: Hey, name, name another postseason run that matches. You can't. You can't.

[00:11:29] Katie Nolan: I could. I could if I prepped.

[00:11:31] Jody Avirgan: Iconic. Iconic. See, I'm picking a word, repeating it. Iconic.

[00:11:35] Katie Nolan: Okay, you're right. It is... It's perfect. That's a good take. It's also not that hot, to be honest.

[00:11:37] Jody Avirgan: No, it's not that hot. I know. I know.

[00:11:39] Katie Nolan: It's not that hot. And the fact that they lost to the Lakers makes it hot that you think that it's the greatest postseason run and it didn't end in a championship. So that is the, the heart of what makes that hot. But it's a decent...

[00:11:51] Jody Avirgan: Yeah.

[00:11:52] Katie Nolan: It's a decent take. I could have used more screaming, but it was a good take.

[00:12:00] Jody Avirgan: Okay. I appreciate it.

That's a very generous assessment of my take. I know. And I appreciate you too, listener, for enduring that. I guess I'm really not cut out for this sort of thing. I'm just so averse to the unimpeachable statement. I really like uncertainty. You know?

A couple other thoughts on why this world isn't for everyone. For one, for Katie. Let's just be honest here. It's a lot harder to do this as a woman than as a man. There's a lot of testosterone in those studios.

If you decided to go full Stephen A. Smith tomorrow.

[00:12:34] Katie Nolan: Oof. Okay.

[00:12:34] Jody Avirgan: You just woke up and said, "I'm gonna do this." What would the reaction be?

[00:12:38] Katie Nolan: Huh. I think I would get a lot more, uh, anger and vitriol, I think, and part of that, not all of it, but part of that's 'cause I'm a woman. Um, when you start to kind of try to go in that direction, they are like, "Well, we give it to them. So we're giving it to you twice as hard."

[00:12:57] Jody Avirgan: Regardless, for Katie, this kind of fighting, it's just too much.

[00:13:03] Katie Nolan: I don't know. I'd probably be too tired by the third day. The real answer to your question is if I woke up tomorrow and I was gonna be Steven A. by Friday, I'd be like this. I'm tired, and I would go back to being me.

[00:13:13] Jody Avirgan: That's actually one of my biggest takeaways from all this too. It just seems exhausting: getting into character, preparing for battle, having to be dialed up to 11 all the time. What is it doing to people? What's it doing to us?

[00:13:28] Katie Nolan: I don't know that humans are built to feel this passionately about six different things every day, because when you think about it, that's what it is. If you're filling up a show, you're gonna basically talk about five or six things every day, and you have to, you know, be emotional and, uh, invested in all of them. I know for me personally, that that's a lot of things to, to care about. I think it's, it, it wears on you to constantly have to have something to say.

[00:14:00] Jody Avirgan: It wears on the people who have to do it. And here's the thing, it may also have a larger cost for all of us, because it sends a message.

[00:14:09] Katie Nolan: If you take TV at face value, it tells you that you should be that fired up about things all the time.

[00:14:14] Jody Avirgan: Yeah.

[00:14:14] Katie Nolan: And that the best people who care the most about sports have opinions about every single thing, every day. So much so that they have to yell about it. And so it might make somebody think, "There has to be something that I'm really mad about all the time." And it's like, that's not true. You can kind of sometimes just be like, "Yeah, I don't care about that."

[00:14:32] Jody Avirgan: And this isn't just in sports. Flip to a 24-hour news channel or hop on social. This idea that we have to be mad about everything everywhere, all the time. Hm. Now, it seems like maybe instead of trying to get myself into this headspace, we should be trying to get more people out of it.

[00:14:50] Katie Nolan: And this could be one of those "which is the chicken, which is the egg"-type situations. But the way that sports fans interact with each other on the internet is very intensely and with a lot of emotion. A lot of times anger that seems unwarranted and

unrelated to the topic at hand. And so you have these people with this emotion who like to yell at people for their dumb takes now yelling at people over things that are more important than that and truly matter to them. Um, that's where it became more clear to me because it was like watching us talk about other things the way we talk about sports is a mess.

[00:15:33] Jody Avirgan: Yeah, man. I feel that I've seen that. Before my time at ESPN, I covered politics. I covered the 2016 presidential election. Whew. Bad faith takes: they are everywhere.

Coming from everyone: on cable news, on politics podcasts, on Blue Wave Twitter and MAGA Twitter, and the incentives to behave this way are real. For a shout guy on tv, it's a big contract. For a keyboard warrior or a barstool blowhard, it's more and more likes and shares. For a presidential candidate, it's a few thousand votes in Wisconsin.

And that's got me worried. I'm worried. I think most people are rational and calm, but when we're in the wrong environment, the better angels of our nature take a backseat, especially when everything we see on TV or from our politicians is modeling the worst possible behavior. That's the environment we're in right now: full of cacophony and speed and meanness.

To me, it all just kind of feels like sports talk. And the thing is, there's a history here, an actual connection you can trace. The world of sports talk and the world of news and politics talk are deeply intertwined, especially over the last 40 years or so. We didn't get here by accident. As they say on TV, that's after the break.

[BREAK]

[00:17:05] Jody Avirgan: So at this point, I want to understand more about this genre of sports media, where it came from, why it's so popular, and the relationship between this kind of argument and other debate formats that seem to be coarsening all around me.

[00:17:18] Jim Miller: Look, I've been on a lot of talk radio shows, and, uh, sometimes you need to take a shower afterwards.

[00:17:23] Jody Avirgan: James Andrew Miller, or as he introduced himself, Jim, is an expert on this kind of content.

[00:17:30] Jim Miller: A lot of times it's very, very animated with words as opposed to statistics or theories or examinations of things.

[00:17:41] Jody Avirgan: For many years, Jim worked in politics. Then he became a media executive, and now he's a journalist and a historian who hosts the Origins podcast and has literally written the book—several big books actually—on institutions like HBO, SNL, CAA, and ESPN. He likes acronyms, I guess. And JAM says the antagonism of these shows really is a core feature of public debate.

[00:18:06] Jim Miller: You just feel like it, it's the deep end of the pool in the sense that there's just, there is no affection, there is no camaraderie, and if you wanna personally insult someone, that's even better.

[00:18:19] Jody Avirgan: Yeah.

[00:18:20] Jim Miller: You know, or, or remember the gesticulations, you know, and like throwing things on, like pounding the table or getting up and walking away, or pacing around the room. I mean, it is, uh, it's a three-ring circus sometimes.

[00:18:36] Jody Avirgan: Jim says it wasn't always like this. In fact, back in the eighties, when ESPN was just getting off the ground, a commentator sharing their personal opinion, getting heated on air, it was not the norm. It was a tenor.

[00:18:49] Jim Miller: It was a tenor. The DNA of it was not bombastic; it wasn't caustic. It was highly respectful. It may have become animated when people were disagreeing, but I think one of the other things that was a hallmark of early sports discussions was that these

people were supposed to be agnostic. They were supposed to be objective. Basically, they were being capital-J Journalists covering things without a lot of subjectivity.

[00:19:20] Jody Avirgan: So what happened? Well, a long time ago, in what feels like a universe very far, far away, TV shows could capture huge audiences pretty much just by being on air. In 1988, the most watched episode of TV ever was the series finale of M*A*S*H. 106 million viewers tuned in. But with the rise of cable TV in the 90s and early 2000s, the 24-hour content cycle fully established. The market was flooded with options. Think about our modern-day equivalent to that M*A*S*H finale, Game of Thrones. It felt like everyone was tuning into that final episode in 2019. The numbers? Less than 20 million viewers, a fifth of the audience that M*A*S*H got. So if you are on TV with all these options and all this fracturing in the attention economy, all you can try and do is cut through the noise.

The absolute standard of this approach, this new era of programming, was CNN's Crossfire. You may have heard of it. Jon Stewart famously called it "partisan hackery" that was hurting America. But for now, let's just say that it featured two hosts, one conservative and one liberal, who sat down with a prominent guest and argued about the news for an hour every day. It was a hit.

[00:20:39] Jim Miller: Yeah, I mean, look, CNN's Crossfire was popular, and it was, according to some, outta control.

[00:20:47] Jody Avirgan: And it made others notice. Others, like Mark Shapiro, a producer at ESPN.

[00:20:53] Jim Miller: Shapiro said, "Look, let's do a Crossfire of sports." I mean, because in a way, sports is even more cut out for that kind of banter and that kind of, you know, arguing.

[00:21:04] Jody Avirgan: Shapiro soon became ESPN's head of programming and production.

[00:21:08] Jim Miller: And the first thing he did was he took Tony Kornheiser and Michael Wilbon from the Washington Post. And Pardon the Interruption (PTI) was founded.

[00:21:18] Jody Avirgan: Pardon the Interruption. PTI. Another acronym, one of my favorite shows. A show that almost needs no introduction, but here's a quick primer. Two sports commentators, Tony Kornheiser and Michael Wilbon, sit at a desk and argue about sports for about half an hour every day. Just like Crossfire, PTI was a hit. And just like Crossfire, other networks took notice.

[00:21:42] Jim Miller: We can't overstate how impactful PTI was. There are so many aspects of that show—the clock, the background, the nature of the banter and the way that all the imagery filled the screen—that was so truly revolutionary.

[00:21:59] Jody Avirgan: The PTI set was over-the-top, colorful, and so were the characters that Tony and Mike brought to the stage each afternoon.

[00:22:06] Jim Miller: I think PTI was a, a huge, huge kind of paradigm shift in, in terms of sports coverage.

[00:22:14] Jody Avirgan: PTI was also one of the first shows to openly understand and cater to declining attention spans. One way was with the now-legendary rundown clock.

[00:22:26] Jim Miller: One of the things that PTI did that was alarming at first, and people thought that this is ridiculous because one of the key concepts before was you don't want the screen to be distracting. Well, they put the menu of topics on the right-hand side and they had a freaking clock going.

And I think this is one of the big steps forward in terms of short-attention-span theater. What they realized is that it was comforting and attractive for them to see what was coming up.

And if they're, they're all of a sudden they're talking about horse racing and you don't care about horse racing, guess

what? You're not gonna tune away because you see that in 30 seconds with the clock, they're going to hockey, and you want that.

[00:23:15] Jody Avirgan: And cable news took some cues from that, right?

[00:23:19] Jim Miller: Absolutely. I mean, it didn't take long for that menu to show up on other shows, and I think it became very, very effective.

[00:23:31] Jody Avirgan: I wanna be clear about something. PTI was the first of its kind. It has had a huge influence on debate shows, and it is also incredibly special. It is smart, it is light, it is real. If I could be Michael Wilbon or Tony Kornheiser, I would in an instant.

[00:23:47] Jim Miller: Well, the beauty of Michael and Tony is that they were themselves. These guys were not trying to be TV stars. They were basically doing what they would always been doing. The only difference was there was a camera on them.

[00:24:00] Jody Avirgan: Sum it up with one word: authenticity. Some shows manufacture conflict to fill a time slot or jack up ratings. Not PTI. And another thing that makes the show special: these guys, Tony and Mike, they really respect each other. You can tell when you watch the show.

[00:24:17] Jim Miller: Well, I think that's a good point because look: in cable news and sports talk, you get the feeling that these people not only don't respect each other, they don't even like each other. It becomes personal. It becomes too caustic. There is a very fine line that you want when you're doing an opinionated show because you want there to be conflict, obviously, or at least a dis—you know, some sort of discussion that is going to show myriad opinions.

But at the same time, anybody watching PTI knows at the end of the day, as soon as the camera's off, these guys are gonna go for a drink or hug it out or anything. I mean, because they are colleagues, they are professionals, and they respect each other and genuinely like each other.

[00:25:04] Jody Avirgan: Authenticity, respect, actual well-reasoned arguments. These ingredients make PTI great and a successful show right from the start. So it makes sense that people would try to imitate it, but the problem comes when the imitators just aren't as good, and they try to copy the style, not the substance. Things like respect and authenticity get lost along the way. Things like listening, maybe even changing your mind, they just aren't part of the equation. What you end up with is a coarsening, a carbon copy of a carbon copy of a carbon copy.

[00:25:41] Jim Miller: And I think that what happens is if you watch some of these shows or you listen to some of these shows, you can almost hear in the back of the person's mind: "Oh, I gotta, I gotta step it up. Or I gotta, I gotta, you know, take this to another level to keep it going." And uh, or you can imagine a producer looking through a window into the studio saying, "Come on guys, get more animated." Or, "Let's fight it out." Or, "Let's take this to another level." And, at that point, that's artificial. That's not authentic. That is acting and acting is hard.

[00:26:16] Jody Avirgan: It is hard. Like I learned with Katie. I just don't have that in me. Not when talking sports, not when I've talked politics, but plenty of people can find it in themselves to fight nasty, and what they find is that it pays off. Yell loud enough and you'll get more eyes on you.

Eyes, followers, ratings. That's what media executives are constantly searching for, to the point where the lines between the world of, say, sports and the world of politics can feel completely blurred. People like Keith Olbermann have floated between sports and politics

because to ESPN and MSNBC, all that really matters is that this guy can get fired up about something, anything for 30 minutes once a day. Maybe it's LeBron, maybe it's gas prices, who cares? Sports hosts talk politics. Politics hosts talk sports. A hot take is a hot take is a hot take. ESPN once even had Rush Limbaugh doing football commentary for crying out loud.

Is it any surprise then the actual politicians are taking the same approach as the sports bros?

[00:27:25] Jim Miller: A lot of politicians now, they're taking what happens in the sports world as their playbook for getting attention because we are far, far away from having people who basically, you know, their behavior and their speeches between the 40-yard lines. Now, there's kind of benefits, particularly fundraising and having a big band of loyal followers to being in, you know, in those extremes. And so I think a lot of people in politics now are, are playing the sports talk game.

[00:28:02] Jody Avirgan: Yell loud enough, and you might find yourself with a three-year contract or a shiny new office or in the White House.

[00:28:15] Jim Miller: I mean, 20 years from now, when people sit down to really trace the pedigree of how things deteriorated so much, they're gonna also talk about what's lost when the focus is just being outlandish or crazy, or not paying attention.

[00:28:35] Jody Avirgan: So, here we are when this style of debate seems to be all around us. I asked Jim Miller what he thinks the impact of this kind of debate has been, particularly in the world of politics.

[00:28:48] Jim Miller: If you think about it, the shows on primetime and on Fox News and MSNBC, people are going to those shows for comfort, to hear people who have a set of orthodoxies or a view of the world that's in concert with their own. It's almost like going to church on a Sunday, and the great thing is if you watch those shows, you know what to say the next day to your colleagues at the water cooler.

[00:29:12] Jody Avirgan: I started to notice this covering the 2016 election when I'd often hear voters talk about our team and the other team when they're talking about Republicans or Democrats. And it's only gotten worse in the years since. Partisanship is at an all-time high, and it's not based on policy preferences or values, but on picking a team and being against the other side no matter what.

[00:29:36] Jim Miller: And so, I have to say, it's almost like watching SportsCenter, and it's almost like watching PTI, because you're rooting for your causes, you're rooting for your team. The candidates or the politicians are like the MVPs on your team, and it comforts us.

[00:29:58] Jody Avirgan: It's worth returning to PTI for a moment because as influential as it was, there was one key part of that show that didn't get imitated: the fact check. At the end of each episode, Tony Reali, AKA Stat Boy, would come on and talk about all the things that Kornheiser and Wilbon got wrong.

[00:30:17] Jim Miller: I think the fact that they decided to have Tony Reali, the fact check boy, there at the end was... It's, it was just awesome. It was mind-clearing.

[00:30:27] Jody Avirgan: To me, the fact check is about more than just getting the stats right. It's about humility and perspective, the kind of stuff that really isn't part of the equation in most modern shows.

[00:30:41] Jim Miller: It was so comforting to see that a show wasn't afraid of the truth, and in fact wanted to almost kind of like shine the light on those guys and say, "Hey, wait a second. You know what? Uh, not real, not true. Not real." And I can't tell you how many times people said to me, "Why can't they have like a fact-check boy on Meet the Press or, uh, a news

interview show or cable news?" Well, sometimes it would mean that the fact checks would take as long as the show itself, because there were so many things that were wrong.

[00:31:12] Jody Avirgan: But also the, the stance, right? I mean, could you imagine Tucker Carlson or Bill O'Reilly or Chuck Todd allowing a fact check, allowing someone to question their authority?

[00:31:22] Jim Miller: Right. I think there's the ego part of it, but I also, now we get to the really sad part, which is, it doesn't even matter now. I think every single night, somebody on cable news says something that is either, I mean, forget about being morally repugnant, I just, in terms of facts, wrong, and the audience doesn't care. And so even if you were to have somebody come on and say, "Well, that's not true, actually," people don't care.

[00:31:55] Jody Avirgan: This is actually a place where Jim thinks there's still a big difference between sports and politics, and sadly, it's sports that he thinks is more anchored in reality. In sports, there's at least the shared reality of the score, the time on the clock in bounds or out of bounds.

[00:32:11] Jim Miller: There's a ton, a ton of opinion, but then when we actually get down to playing the games, well, there it is right there. So, um, we don't have any of those things in politics and, uh, politics is, is a far, far more dangerous, divisive, destructive world than sports.

[00:32:35] Jody Avirgan: I, of course, agree. It's okay to mouth off about sports, not my cup of tea, but fine. But politics is not a game. The stakes are different. Real people's lives are affected by what politicians say and how they say it. I'm all for the public square. Given this country's history of drowning out so many voices, it's good that more people have more ways to speak out.

But when our environment pushes us to argue for the sake of arguing, when it doesn't come from a place of experience or knowledge or authentic conviction, it's just noise: toxic, toxic noise.

So there you have it. We're all doomed. Thanks for listening.

No, I'm just kidding. We're not gonna end there. Look, there is a path out of this. Maybe. At the end of my talk with Katie, as we were reflecting on the lessons of Sports Talk Bootcamp, I mentioned to her this idea that sports argument was getting coarser, that a lot of the discourse outside of sports is going that way too. And I asked her if she was worried about that.

[00:33:46] Katie Nolan: I worry about everything, Jody, to be honest. Um, I do think we are pretty deep in a swing towards extremes of, like, the anger and, um, misogyny's making a run right now, which is pretty, pretty cool. Um, I think that we can get better and I choose to hope and think that we will.

Um, just because of how the universe works. Things always go like that. They swing back and forth, and I think it's almost time to swing back the other way where we just go back to being like, "Who cares this much?"

[00:34:18] Jody Avirgan: I buy that. I do think these things tend to swing back and forth, but you can also do things to give that pendulum a little push. Katie, who is lucky enough to have a platform, is trying to help.

[00:34:33] Katie Nolan: I feel like I, I worry, but I also, it's kind of what keeps me going and doing this job is I'm like, somebody has to just be the person they want to see on TV, on TV.

[00:34:46] Jody Avirgan: Yeah. Somebody has to be the person they want to see on tv, on TV. Maybe that sounds simple, but it's also kind of brilliant, revelatory even, because in a world where all the incentives are pushing you one way, Katie and lots of other people I respect are saying, "No, let's find another path."

There's a lot that's broken in our politics and media these days. The last several years have been a nightmare, and I gotta say, while I get upset about policies that I disagree with or hypocritical behavior, I also do keep coming back to how our leaders talk, what values they display when they talk. And it sucks to see the worst people in the world get rewarded.

People who should know better.

Is it too much to ask that they try and demonstrate some modicum of virtue, honesty, decency? I really believe that makes a difference. And if you kind of believe the same, but maybe you don't have the platform that Katie Nolan does, here's my advice. Yes, the things we believe in are worth fighting for and sometimes even arguing about.

But ask yourself, do you really need to join that fight online? Do you really think progress happens on cable news? If you have a voice, if you're authentically fired up, remember: your energy, it's a finite resource. Don't get exhausted. Instead, I'd say, do the work where you're already at. Slow down. Focus on the people around you, your family, your schools. Listen to your neighbors. Fight the good fights that you can in the real world. Maybe that's the answer. That's not that preposterous an idea. Preposterous, preposterous, right?

Next time on Good Sport, what in the world is the zone?

[00:36:41] Steph Curry: There's this synergy with everything that you're trying to do, and even your intentions have been validated by the atmosphere around you.

[00:36:48] Jody Avirgan: And why do we obsess over it?

Good Sport is brought to you by the TED Audio Collective. It's hosted by me, Jody Avirgan. The show is produced by TED. This episode was written and produced by Isabel Carter. Our team includes Camille Peterson, Poncie Rutsch, Sarah Nics, Jimmy Gutierrez, Michelle Quint, BanBan Cheng, and Roxanne Hai Lash. Jake Gorski is our sound designer and mix engineer.

Fact-checking by Hannah Matsudaira. Special thanks to Pablo Torre, Brian Rosenwald, Sarah Sobieraj, and Nicole Hemmer. Their research and ideas were all really helpful as we were putting together this episode.

We want to hear from you. Questions, ideas, reactions. Our email is goodsport@ted.com, or you can find me on social media and yell at me there, which was the whole point of this episode.

One last thing if you're game. If you like this episode, hit play in your podcast player and text it to a friend. Even better, text it to a friend who might not think that they're into sports. Who knows, they might be into this show. Thanks again for listening to Good Sport. My name is Jody Avirgan. See you soon.

[BREAK]

[00:38:04] Jody Avirgan: I wanna tell you one Stephen A. story. My Stephen A. story from, from ESPN.

[00:38:07] Katie Nolan: Okay.

[00:38:07] Jody Avirgan: Which is when I got to ESPN, you know, they gave me my ID and my tour of the, of the radio studios on the west side, uh, in Manhattan. Uh, they were like showing me like, this is where they do Mike and Mike, or this is where they do whatever. And they were really showing me different studios. And then we get to like, a closet, and it's like you open the door and it's just like a closet and there's a stool in the middle of the, of the closet. And they're like, "And this is where when Stephen A. isn't in Bristol and he needs to do First Take, he does it from in here. And you know, he sits here and there's like a pinhole camera and he just talks into there, and they green screen the background or whatever." And I was like, "So you're telling me that Stephen A. Smith just walks into this closet, closes the door, and just yells at a dot on the wall for like three hours?"

And they're like, "Yep."

And I was like, "Actually that's probably like his version of heaven." I'm like, no. I don't think there's ever been a person who's more in their perfect element what they were built to be doing than, than just the vision of that.

[00:39:03] Katie Nolan: It's his safe space.

The Truth About "The Zone" (Transcript)

Listen along

Good Sport The Truth About "The Zone"

February 15, 2023

[00:00:00] Jody Avirgan: In sports, there's a lot of talk about a magical place called "the zone". You've probably heard of it. That place where everything clicks, where no matter the weather or the crowd or the sweat in your eyes, nothing can break your focus, where you just do everything perfectly. You sink every shot. Nothing can stop you. Now, when I think about the zone, when I picture someone in the zone, I picture Steph Curry.

Do you believe in the zone?

[00:00:32] Steph Curry: I do believe in the zone, 'cause it's the one time that everything kind of goes autopilot.

[00:00:40] Jody Avirgan: Well, if the greatest NBA shooter of all times says the legend is real, that the zone is real, it's more than just a legend.

[00:00:48] Steph Curry: There's just synergy with everything that you're trying to do, and even your intentions have been validated by the atmosphere around you, where it seems like everything else is going right at the same time. You kind of get lost in that moment.

[00:01:01] Jody Avirgan: I love that phrase. Your intentions are validated by the atmosphere around you. I suppose if I were hitting every shot in the NBA finals in front of a roaring crowd, I'd probably feel like my intentions were validated by the atmosphere as well. But look, here's the thing about the zone. Almost by definition, it is special and fleeting, and you can't force it.

[00:01:24] Steph Curry: You can't control any of that. It's just, for me, when it goes away, it's the reflection on the feeling you just had. I think it's just a natural experience.

[00:01:37] Jody Avirgan: You can recognize when it's gone. But chasing after it is almost a guarantee that you won't get there.

[00:01:44] Steph Curry: I don't think you can train yourself to appreciate it more than just you naturally do. 'Cause if you do, then you start to distract yourself from what's actually happening.

[00:01:55] Jody Avirgan: So you heard it directly from Steph Curry. Nice as it is when you find yourself in the zone, obsessing over getting there—and there is a lot of obsession about the zone—that will get in the way of what you're trying to do.

So today we want to figure out what we can control, what we can train for, because even if the zone is elusive, there are still ways to perform at your best to keep your head in the game.

My name is Jody Avirgan, and from the TED Audio Collective. This is Good Sport.

[BREAK]

[00:02:35] Jody Avirgan: We think about athletes getting their bodies in shape to compete, but talk to top athletes, and a lot of them will say that the mental side of the game is the real key to peak performance. It's one of the things I've thought about most as an athlete: how to get my mind in the right place. To be clear, I'm not talking about mental health or emotional well-being.

Athletes like Simone Biles and Naomi Osaka have started really important conversations about how an athlete's life on and off the court connect. And honestly, those deserve an entire series of their own. What we're talking about in this episode is the mental part of competition. That invisible force that I think shapes every game, every race, every match, and a lot of times, separates the winner from the loser.

[BREAK]

[00:03:36] Jody Avirgan: Dr. Nicole Detling is an expert on the mental side of the game. She's a sports psychologist who's worked with Olympic skiers and skaters, pro baseball and football and soccer players, college gymnasts, athletes at the very top of their sports. When she first meets with these athletes, all they want to talk about is being in the zone.

So when you ask people to describe what it feels like, what language do they use?

[00:04:02] Nicole Detling: Interesting. A lot of them will say things like, "I don't remember much about it." Like, "I just kind of was lost. I wasn't thinking. I was just doing it, and it was amazing, and I loved it, and I wanna get there more."

[00:04:14] Jody Avirgan: But as she starts to work with athletes, she tries to shift their thinking. She tells them not to think about the feeling of being in the zone that they're trying to chase after, but instead that they should work on building a solid and reliable skill. That skill is mental resilience.

[00:04:32] Nicole Detling: Being your best self in all circumstances, whatever that looks like. You know what? I'm only at 70% today, but I'm gonna do my best to give that 70%.

[00:04:39] Jody Avirgan: Mental resilience means being able to find whatever version of calm and focus you can, even when things aren't going your way. Those times when you're trying to get your focus or regain it when something is tugging at your attention. An unexpected move by your opponent, a mistake, bad weather. It's about recovering from those things to still play your best. Mental resilience is not elusive or magical. It's a habit.

[00:05:05] Nicole Detling: We have these thinking processes and patterns and skills that we're teaching people to eventually get it to automate. So it's an automatic process. Rather than having to turn on that mindset, you become that mindset.

[00:05:16] Jody Avirgan: And if we're gonna talk about the mindset required for mental resilience, I want to talk about a sport that I have come to believe requires more of it than maybe any other sport. A sport where a test of mental resilience is baked right into the rules. Biathlon.

Meet Clare Egan, Olympic biathlete. Imagine her cross-country skiing, whizzing through the mountains of northern Italy, consumed by the drive to go fast. In fact, so consumed that she would sometimes lose track of where she was and go off course.

[00:05:52] Clare Egan: It did lead me astray several times, literally, because I was notorious for getting lost.

[00:05:55] Jody Avirgan: Haha. When Clare Egan would ski, she'd get lost in a sort of beautiful haze focused only on her arms, her legs, on pushing forward.

[00:06:06] Clare Egan: I can just focus on my body, my breath. I'm pushing as hard as I can and harder and harder as much as I can.

[00:06:15] Jody Avirgan: But here's the thing: biathlon isn't just a cross-country skiing race where you can allow yourself to get totally lost. No. There's another component, one that would often trip Clare up. Because in biathlon you go from flying across the snow to a full stop... And then, you take a rifle off your back, and on a shooting range that's nearly silent, you peer through a sight and you try and shoot five targets that can be as small as Oreos, 164 feet away. And those shots, it's hard to overstate how much making them matters.

Everything is on the line. If you miss a target, depending on the race, you either have to ski extra laps or have minutes added to your total race time. The pressure is immense.

[00:07:05] Clare Egan: I've grown up watching the Green Bay Packers, 'cause my dad's from Green Bay. And, um, probably most Americans can think of a time when the kicker took the field and of course, there's two seconds or something ridiculous left on the clock. And, and, and you just know. And that kicker knows if they, if they hit that kick the right way, it's gonna be a win for the team. And if they don't, it won't. And every biathlon race is like that for every competitor.

[00:07:32] Jody Avirgan: Except for in football, that kicker didn't spring up and down the sideline 200 times before having to then kick the ball.

[00:07:39] Clare Egan: Exactly. Right? Right.

[00:07:40] Jody Avirgan: So biathlon is this test of body and mind. That's the mental puzzle built into the rules. The big test of resilience. You have to shift your brain from skiing to shooting. Do it quickly. Keep your focus.

But when Clare would fly into the shooting range, dripping with sweat, almost delirious from her high-speed racing, her brain felt blurry and jumbled. Thoughts swirling around as she tried to slow everything down and shoot those five Oreos.

[00:08:16] Clare Egan: I wasn't actually loose enough to be doing what I needed to do, and so sometimes I would leave the range having missed three out of five, and I'm thinking to myself, "What did I just do out there? I don't even know what I did."

[00:08:30] Jody Avirgan: Is it true that most people miss the last shot or people miss the last shot more than the others?

[00:08:35] Clare Egan: The shooting statistics for the last shot would be worse than for the other shots, but, but that's probably only if you've hit all your other shots.

[00:08:42] Jody Avirgan: Mm-hm. But what's going on there?

[00:08:45] Clare Egan: You know exactly what's on the line. It's easy to become distracted because you start thinking about the outcome. It's such a distraction. It's a distraction that is being shoved in your face, and it's unavoidable. So you have to be strong in your mind. You have to be well prepared to say, "Okay, I'm distracted. Now what?"

[00:09:07] Jody Avirgan: Now what? Clare was competing in major events, the world championships, the Olympics, and she wanted medals. She needed to figure out a strategy for how to handle the mental challenge at the heart of her sport. So she made a routine.

As a first step, Clare tried to identify what she called her transition area by looking at the race course. She'd show up early and plot out where on the course she had to start shifting her mind from "I need to go as fast as I can" to "I need to breathe and focus". She'd pick a change in the terrain or a landmark, like a flagpole.

[00:09:42] Clare Egan: And physically, at that point, I would bring my pace down to a level where I'm no longer accumulating more oxygen debt. So I'm not, I'm not, I don't wanna be getting any more tired than I already am.

[00:09:58] Jody Avirgan: And once she got on the shooting range, she started using what she called an emergency check to make sure that she'd really made the transition.

[00:10:07] Clare Egan: The last thing I need to do is sort of like put my cheek down on my, on my cheek piece and, and look out through the sights. The last thing I did before I would lower my head is I would make sure that I could see the target clearly with my eyes, like that I wasn't so tired and out of it that I was, like, blurry because sometimes I was really seeing blurry. And so, I would kind of double check, "Okay, like, am I seeing the target clearly? Okay, yeah. Now I can make intelligent decisions about what I'm doing on the shooting range."

[00:10:40] Jody Avirgan: It was all about finding simple, repeatable cues, a routine that could consistently get her mind where it needed to be. This would also help Clare handle the pressure of shooting. Quiet that inner voice that was saying, "If I hit this, then..."

[00:10:57] Clare Egan: "Then I'll have hit all five." Like, that's not a helpful thought. And when you recognize "Oh, I've had that thought. That's not helpful," then you can replace it with something that actually is helpful like, "Okay, I had that thought. That's fine. Now I'm gonna take one more breath, exhale, and then do a really good job on the trigger."

[00:11:17] Jody Avirgan: Keeping her mind focused on process is how Clare learned to handle shooting mistakes as well. I asked her to tell me about a time when she really struggled with recovering from an error.

Sorry, not to take you there.

[00:11:33] Clare Egan: Through every race... Um, I could think one of the most painful ones was a race outta world championships, where I hit the first 17 and then missed the last 3.

[00:11:46] Jody Avirgan: That thing about biathletes struggling with their final shots, it happened to Clare. 17 in a row, then missed the final three? Brutal.

[00:11:56] Clare Egan: It was a minute of time penalty per miss, You know, to be in medal contention and then miss the last, like to throw it away in three seconds at the end of the race was so painful.

[00:12:08] Jody Avirgan: When Clare thinks back to that world championship race, she's struck by how certain she was that she'd make all her shots. In her mind, it was the only possible outcome.

[00:12:18] Clare Egan: And my third to last shot, I think was probably really, really close. In fact, I know it was close. It was, like, what's called a split. It was like half in, half out, but it didn't, the target didn't go down.

And I got so distracted by that. I, it, I, like, I probably flinched. I, I was so shocked that I missed and instead of, um, resetting, I don't even remember taking the last two shots. You know, I was not, I was distracted.

[00:12:43] Jody Avirgan: She lost sight of what she had to do to shoot well, like checking the wind direction, adjusting her sights, and having a steady trigger squeeze on every shot. This process versus outcome thing, I think it's bled from sports into the rest of the world almost to the point of cliché. I've heard of people in office meetings talk about focusing on process. It's worked its way into the world of self-help books and podcasts. Oh God, is this a self-help podcast? But yeah, focusing on process is really, really hard because there are all these moments when outcome tries to rear its ugly head and throw you, and you have to try and refocus on the steps you need to take right now.

But thinking back to that world championship, Clare also sees a deeper lesson about the mindset it takes to perform at the highest level. After her race was done, she ran into a friend of hers who at the time was the best biathlete in the world. He'd made a similar mistake at the Olympics. He missed his last few shots.

[00:13:46] Clare Egan: He was kind of joking, you know, "How badly did you just throw away your race?" And I'm like, "Real bad, real badly." And I, but I said, "Hey, you know, but I, I think I remember you doing it in, in Korea too, so you know, I'm maybe not alone. Even heroes do this kind of thing." And he said, "Yeah, that's true. That happened to me. But I won the next day."

And that reminded me that what happens the next day is completely unrelated to what happened the day before. It's a fresh slate, and that's the beautiful thing.

[00:14:20] Jody Avirgan: The one term I've always thought was just sort of, flush it, right? Something goes bad, flush it, and then you just move on. That was awesome.

[00:14:25] Clare Egan: Oh yeah. This, and, and people who are awesome at their sport are flushing a lot. What can you learn and then move on and never think about it again?

[00:14:39] Jody Avirgan: Okay, we're 15 minutes into this episode. You just learned something, flush it. Let's move on.

[BREAK]

[00:15:00] Jody Avirgan: Growing up, Dr. Nicole Detling loved sports.

[00:15:03] Nicole Detling: In fact, I was the first girl in my school to play football.

[00:15:05] Jody Avirgan: She ended up running track and playing basketball in college. Just focused on her game, wins and losses, points scored, having fun with her teammates. But one day, she was having a chat with her dad.

[00:15:17] Nicole Detling: My dad called me and said, "Did you know there's a field called sports psychology?" And I said, "What? No."

[00:15:23] Jody Avirgan: A whole new world opened up. Eventually, it would become her career, but it also started to change the way she played. One of the first things that shifted, something she now works on with her athletes, was just a basic understanding that the mental side of the game is always there.

[00:15:41] Nicole Detling: Every time you play physically, every time you train, every time you think about your sport, your mind is involved. If you don't know what's going through your mind, you're not aware of what's helping you and what's hurting you. And quite frankly, it's not even just sports. It's life, it's business, it's performance. It's everything we do every day.

[00:15:59] Jody Avirgan: Yeah. And talk about something that feels like it's worked its way into larger culture, but just mindfulness, and staying in the moment and just going one moment at a time. I mean that's, you know, that's exploded in sports, but in real life too. We have a, we have apps, you know, that are trying to get us to focus on just this one moment.

[00:16:16] Nicole Detling: Yeah. And it's so difficult in this world when we have so many things pulling on our attention. Our phone dings, our computer dings, the TV. You know, we always say in sports, the most important play is this play, and then this play.

[00:16:30] Jody Avirgan: There's a line in one of my favorite books about the mental side of sports called *The Inner Game of Tennis*. It goes, "It is perplexing to wonder why we ever leave the here and now. Here and now are the only place in time when one ever enjoys himself or accomplishes anything." And I think about that a lot. How performing well at anything—being an athlete, being a manager, being a partner, being a parent—is often about giving the present your full attention.

So when athletes come to Dr. Detling, she convinces them that they need to work on the mental side of the game, and then, she gets to work, to build that mental resilience.

[00:17:11] Nicole Detling: What I'll often do is ask athletes, "Okay, tell me how you warm up, or what do you do between plays? What do you do? What's your process?" And then I'll say, "Okay, at each one of those points, what are you doing mentally?"

And most people don't know what they're doing mentally. So then what I'll do is say, "Okay, well here's what we've been working on. So I don't want you to change what you're doing physically, but when you do this, let's tie in that." So maybe you were saying a confident statement to yourself. Maybe you're reminding yourself what your assignment is on that play.

[00:17:37] Jody Avirgan: Yeah. I mean, I have, you know, memories; it's one of my favorite sort of things. It's like during a really high-level game, let's say, there's, you know, 10 people on the field or the court, or 15 people or whatever, you know, if you were just like, at a supercritical moment. You know, if you were to look around or even close your eyes and

listen, you know, be like, "This person's muttering to themselves. This person's singing a song. This person's tugging on their, on their lucky jersey."

[00:18:00] Nicole Detling: Yes. Yes!

[00:18:00] Jody Avirgan: "This person is like..." So, you know, but it's like everyone's just doing their own little, their little thing. But it's a, you know, you take half a step back and you're like, "Wow, look at these bunch—"

[00:18:10] Nicole Detling: I know!

[00:18:10] Jody Avirgan: A bunch of people up top.

[00:18:12] Nicole Detling: Yeah. I couldn't agree more. And that's why I, I, that's what the, those are the things that I look for when I go and hang out with teams.

[00:18:17] Jody Avirgan: Yeah.

[00:18:18] Nicole Detling: Is I'm looking for baseline. "So I've noticed you do this. First of all, did you know you did that? Second of all, why are you doing that? And third of all, what's happening mentally while you're doing that?" If that's something you're gonna do, let's use it. Let's utilize it in a positive way that gets you ready for the next play.

[00:18:35] Jody Avirgan: There are some things I do to try and keep my mind calm and my body ready. Before taking the field in Ultimate, I'd always do three tuck jumps, just the little routine to center myself, and I actually don't think I've ever said this to anyone, but for, like, 20 years as I've played sports or worked out, I've had this little snippet of a song that runs through my head, something I find myself humming.

[HUMMING]

I have no idea what that song is, but it just shows up whenever I'm trying to get into that flow state. Hundreds of times a year for 20 years. I probably owe whoever wrote that song serious royalties. But for all my humming and tuck jumps, I've still struggled with slipping out of the moment. So much of mental resilience is realizing that everything isn't gonna go perfectly.

I've worked on that. I've worked on, here's one of my favorite cliches, getting comfortable being uncomfortable. The good news, Dr. Detling says, is that you can train for that.

[00:19:37] Nicole Detling: Some of the things that we've done with some of the skiing Olympians that I've worked with, and actually I'll talk about speed skating too, is we've not waxed their skis, and they've had to train with unwaxed skis, right? With speed skating, you know what, your blades aren't quite as sharp as you would want them to be.

Train that way. Train with, you know, forgetting, you know, there's a little tiny little tear in your suit. Train without your goggles one time. That's why a lot of teams will pipe in crowd noise, so they can't hear during training sessions. They can't hear each other, and they're working on those things and training for those things, because at the end of the day, we all wanna show up and feel great, but yet there will be comp days, sometimes the biggest competition of your life, and you show up feeling like crap. If you've trained feeling like crap, then you know you can compete feeling like crap.

[00:20:28] Jody Avirgan: Okay, so you can train for the uncomfortable moments, train to keep some focus when there are uncontrollable external circumstances. But what about the internal? What about when you, yourself are the problem? When your own thoughts are distracting you? That voice that pops up at all of the wrong moments telling you how badly you're doing, how much the game is slipping out of your hands.

When she was a college athlete playing basketball, this is the kind of thinking that really tripped up Dr. Detling and really propelled her to want to explore the mental side of the game.

[00:21:03] Nicole Detling: I was basically my own living, walking, self-fulfilling prophecy where I'd get fouled, and I'd be going to the free throw line thinking, "Oh my gosh, I'm gonna miss this. Oh, I can't miss this. I really don't need to miss this. Oh, come on, Nicole."

[00:21:14] Jody Avirgan: I mean, listening to that, I just missed a free throw here in the studio.

[00:21:20] Nicole Detling: So I was setting myself up for failure and assuming I was gonna fail before I even got there and gave myself a chance.

[00:21:24] Jody Avirgan: Today, this is a big part of what Dr. Detling works on with athletes: self-talk. I think we all know what self-talk is, and we can understand that she was hurting her performance with all that negative self-talk. We get, too, that the opposite is positive self-talk. "I can do this. I got this." That kind of thing. But Dr. Detling thinks it's a little more nuanced than just positive and negative. It's really about what does the talk do for you. Here's her example. She's a runner, and she lives in Utah where it can get to a hundred degrees in the summer, but she's out there running anyway.

[00:22:04] Nicole Detling: And there will be times that I will catch myself out there going, "Oh my gosh. It is so hot." Yeah, that's true. "Oh my gosh, I'm so tired. My legs are so heavy." Both of those things are true. And then I start thinking, "Oh, I could just call my husband, and he can come pick me up. Oh, I could take this short way home." And what I'll recognize in the moment is none of those thoughts are helping me achieve what I'm out there to do, which is run. And that's negative self-talk.

I will catch myself, and Jody, I will literally say to myself: "Nicole, you're being fucking stupid. Run." What it does for me in that moment is I flip a switch and I run. So in that moment, that is positive self-talk because it's getting me to where I wanna be to do what I want to do.

[00:22:51] Jody Avirgan: So yeah, it's important to think about helpful self-talk and try and keep unhelpful self-talk at arm's distance. But easier said than done. We all know what it's like for your mind to wander, and then all of a sudden you're back at self-doubt, that unhelpful voice in your head. This is where Dr. Detling introduces a concept I hadn't really heard before. Honestly, my biggest takeaway from our entire conversation: neutral self-talk; neutral self-talk is basically keeping your mind occupied and ready, but not exhausted.

[00:23:26] Nicole Detling: What I'll often tell people to do is just in your mind, commentate what you see around you. All right. Number 10 has the ball. They're moving up to midfield. I'm gonna run to that open space. Okay? They passed it to the right. I'm gonna drop back a little bit, make sure this guy's covered over my shoulder.

[00:23:40] Jody Avirgan: Neutral self-talk is like hold music for your mind.

[00:23:44] Nicole Detling: And when you're thinking neutral, you're not thinking negative, and your confidence can rest. You can play in neutral. You can live in neutral. Neutral's a great place to be.

[00:23:57] Jody Avirgan: Man, I wish I knew about neutral self-talk years ago. Because when I played sports, it was rarely neutral. I'd often ride a rollercoaster of emotions, and often the emotion I most felt was anger. I've always been one of those athletes fueled by anger and a bit of animosity towards my opponent.

Anyone who's played against me probably didn't have a very fun time. I often didn't have much fun playing. Maybe I was kind of a dick, but it was also hurting my game. I didn't have Dr. Detling all those years ago when I was driven by anger, but I have her now.

How do you handle someone who is, who's driven by that?

[00:24:39] Nicole Detling: Well, let me ask you. Let's do it. Let's do a little bit of work here. So, how do you find that place of anger where you like to be? How do you get there?

[00:24:46] Jody Avirgan: Um, just get petty, but like intentionally, right? But just, you know, or

if it's a rivalry and it's someone I know, you know, use something from a previous match. But, you know, I always find that spark. Like, I don't think I cheated, but I would often early in a game, find a way to scuffle with someone or talk a little shit or be aggrieved in some way. Just something, a spark to get me motivated and fired up.

[00:25:15] Nicole Detling: Okay, and if we go, like, think of a scale of one to 10, where 10 is like as angry as you have ever been. Like probably maybe even a little too far anger. One is you have zero, you're just kind of there playing. What's your ideal level of anger?

[00:25:29] Jody Avirgan: I mean, it's definitely not a 10, right? Because I think I know what it feels like to be out of control. Um, and be, and the diminishing aspect of that. But you know, it's close. An eight.

[00:25:44] Nicole Detling: Mm-hmm. Mm-hm. Eight, okay.

[00:25:45] Jody Avirgan: Or seven.

[00:25:45] Nicole Detling: Okay.

[00:25:46] Jody Avirgan: You know, I can't be, I can't be at a four.

[00:25:48] Nicole Detling: So let's say if it's a, if it's an eight, then your ideal range would be a seven to a nine. So eight's where you wanna be. Seven, a little too low, but you're okay there. Nine, a little too high, but you're okay there. And so if you get to that 10, you have to have your strategies to bring you back down. And if you are at a six or lower, what are your strategies to bring you up? And it sounds like for you, beginning a game, sometimes you have to fabricate it. It's just not there naturally. So then let's go to what are your specific strategies to fabricate that anger that's not there inherently?

[00:26:20] Jody Avirgan: Right. I mean, yeah.

[00:26:20] Nicole Detling: And you talked about opponents. Yeah. Go ahead. What else do you have on that?

[00:26:24] Jody Avirgan: Right. No, and I mean to me, you know, I think the thing that I've always prided myself on and I think has put me in a position to, when I've performed well, performed well is just a level of intensity in everything.

[00:26:36] Nicole Detling: Ah.

[00:26:36] Jody Avirgan: And so, you know, it's, it's the warmup, it's the behavior on the sideline. It's maybe, you know, mixing it up with teammates in what feels like a way that it's, we're pushing each other up. Um, but, you know, I can't, I can't just flip the switch. I kind of have to be in this stew of intensity.

[00:26:54] Nicole Detling: Okay. Well, there you go. So now you're using the word intensity instead of anchor, so which is it? Is there a difference between those for you?

[00:27:04] Jody Avirgan: Mm-hm. Right. Yeah. And maybe that's, maybe that's the difference between 7 and 10, right?

[00:27:08] Nicole Detling: Mm-hm.

[00:27:08] Jody Avirgan: And, and anger, feeling like something that you're sort of holding onto the live wire, um, and intensity feeling like something you something can ride a little bit.

[00:27:15] Nicole Detling: There you go. Now, now thinking about the difference between those two. Anger can be really hard to facilitate, but intensity is a lot easier. And so—

[00:27:23] Jody Avirgan: Yeah.

[00:27:23] Nicole Detling: —even identifying the difference between those two for you can be incredibly powerful.

[00:27:29] Jody Avirgan: Listener, I promise, going forward I will podcast with intensity, not anger. Deep breath. Deep breath.

The mental side of sports, it's a new frontier. No surprise. With all the money in sports, people are trying to figure out shortcuts. Shortcuts to focus. Some kind of magical zone pill

or resilience wearable or whatever. Athletes are experimenting with computer simulations to train their minds. There's research into supplements and hormones that might calm our brains. I tried to put Steph Curry in an MRI machine during our interview. He was not having it.

I want to tell you about the vagus nerve. It's a bundle of nerves, we all have it, that runs up your neck and around your ear. It connects all the way down to your heart and your gut. Some people think it might be the key to how your brain and body interact.

There's a lot of research into vagus nerve stimulation and devices you can wear to activate it with the goal of relaxing your mind and body. A lot of these devices attach at your ear and create a sort of low-level sound and vibration. There's these videos that show someone wearing a vagus nerve stimulator and they're on a putting green, and they just stand there calmly sinking one putt after another.

In fact, over the last 45 seconds or so, we've been playing a version of that sound. If you are wearing headphones right now, you are likely entering the zone. Try it out. Go take some free throws, do some writing. Take a knife, throw it in the air, you'll catch it by the handle.

Nah, I'm just messing with you. Dr. Detling says vagus nerve stimulation might help some athletes in some sports. It seems to depend on the person and the situation, and it's hard to know how much is just placebo effect. It's just not that simple, which is actually what makes this so wonderful. Think about how dynamic sports are, how complicated the ecosystem of a game is.

Every time you go out there to compete, there's you, there's your opponent, different players, different plays, a different field, different weather. But research is done on controlling variables so that someone like Dr. Detling can say X caused Y.

[00:29:59] Nicole Detling: I will often get asked, you know, where's the objective evidence or the data that shows that what you do makes an impact?

And there isn't any, I don't have any other than athletes saying that it makes an impact.

Coaches saying that it makes an impact. People continuing to come back to me year after year, after year, hire me year after year after year. It's, it does make an impact, but we don't have the scientific evidence to prove that. It's just not... We just don't have the capacity to study it yet. Perhaps someday we will.

[00:30:31] Jody Avirgan: I love the idea that sports are too dynamic to study: the drama, the constant change, the unpredictability. It's what can make sports feel like life. Life is usually more messy than clean. Lord knows it's uncomfortable. But that's where the lessons you learn in sports can teach you something about the rest of your life, too.

[00:30:52] Nicole Detling: I've personally had what, 10, 12 surgeries now related to sports. So an athlete comes to me with an ACL, I'm like, "Yeah, I know. I've been there. I got you. Okay, let's do this."

You know, so whether it's, you know, having those injuries or it's having, you know, personal struggles. I'm on my second marriage. My first husband just walked out the door one day when my kids were six and three, and so as horrible as that experience was and to go through that experience, it's helped me help other people who go through similar things. We are all so much stronger than we think. We can get through so much more than we think, and that's part of what mental toughness is all about, is not that you're always this stud out there, but that you're pushing through whatever it is that you're dealing with, you're figuring it out, and some days it's easier than others, but you continue to persevere.

[00:31:44] Jody Avirgan: You do your best on your worst days. You leave your mistakes behind. Flush it. Get comfortable being uncomfortable. And on those days where everything is clicking, where you race across the snow and make all your shots, where you're the Steph

Curry of reading books to your kids, you just try to stay in the moment. Why would we ever leave the here and now? Here and now are the only place in time when one ever enjoys oneself or accomplishes anything.

[BREAK]

[00:32:25] Jody Avirgan: On the next episode of Good Sport:

[00:32:28] David Samson: “What should we do here, ethically?” never, ever comes up when you're negotiating a stadium deal.

[00:32:34] Jody Avirgan: Is there such a thing as a good stadium deal or maybe just a less bad one?

Good Sport is brought to you by the TED Audio Collective. It's hosted by me, Jody Avirgan. This show is produced by TED. This episode was written and produced by Camille Peterson. Our team includes Isabel Carter, Poncie Rutsch Sarah Nics, Jimmy Gutierrez, Michelle Quint, BanBan Cheng, and Roxanne Hai Lash. Jake Gorski is our sound designer and mix engineer.

Fact-checking by Nicole Pasulka. We'll be back soon with more Good Sport. Make sure you're following Good Sport in your favorite podcast app so you get every episode delivered straight to your device and leave us a review. We love hearing from our listeners. See you soon.

The Hidden World of Stadium Deals (Transcript)

Listen along

Good Sport The Hidden World of Stadium Deals

March 1, 2023

[00:00:00] Jody Avirgan: On April 4th, 2012, the Miami Marlins opened their baseball season at a brand new stadium. The Marlins' new stadium was pretty snazzy; colorful sidewalks led you to the stadium doors, and inside you'd see replicas of work from famous artists: Miró, Lichtenstein. If the Marlins scored a home run, a rainbow sculpture sprang into action, marlin fish spinning and leaping over neon lights and palm trees.

There was a swimming pool, tropical fish tanks, a bobblehead museum. This whole new stadium with its dazzling features happened in large part because of one guy. His name is David Samson.

[00:00:43] David Samson: I get credit for having negotiated a great stadium deal in Miami and for keeping the Marlins in Miami.

[00:00:47] Jody Avirgan: Okay. Yeah. Not everyone thinks it was a great stadium deal. Ask people in Miami. Go ahead, google “worst stadium deals in history”. It'll pop up. But anyway, David Samson was president of the Marlins during the stadium negotiations. The deal he brokered was for a \$500 million ballpark. The Marlins, mostly their owner, Jeffrey Loria, covered about a third of the cost. And who covered the rest?

Miami-Dade County and the city of Miami, which means the people of Miami. Their tax money covered the majority of the price tag: \$350 million. That's a pretty expensive ballpark, even though when you're talking about ballparks, the numbers are always really big. The promises are often big too, but 10 years later, the fish tanks are gone, and so is the pool. The youth baseball academy that they'd promised finally broke ground in 2021, 9 years behind schedule. And get this: because of how the city financed the loans for their portion of the deal, Marlins Park has ended up costing Miami taxpayers more than 2 billion dollars—4 times the number that was initially discussed.

I want to know how these deals come together. So yeah, that's why I wanted to talk to David Samson, the guy who says he gets credit for this great deal. Guys like David make deals like this happen. Guys like David who talk like this.

[00:02:18] David Samson: When you're negotiating anything—forget a stadium, when you're negotiating with your significant other about where you want to go on vacation or where you want to go to dinner, or what color you want to paint a bathroom—

[00:02:28] Jody Avirgan: In my house, we call that a conversation, but you can call it a negotiation, but go ahead.

[00:02:32] David Samson: Well, make no mistake, everything's a negotiation. There are no conversations.

[00:02:38] Jody Avirgan: Yeesh, can you believe this guy? But look, that is who is in the room. I am fascinated by negotiations like this, by deals like this. I love a beautiful new stadium. Of course, every sports fan does. I love taking my daughter to Citi Field for Mets games.

She doesn't understand baseball at all, but we really enjoy the stadium. We love the ice cream. We love when Mr. Met falls off the top of the dugout. And at the same time, I know that Citi Field cost a ton of money, about 850 million dollars. The taxpayers of New York chipped in for most of that. There was a fight from the neighborhood in Queens about what the development would do to local businesses.

When you go, the stadium does feel kind of disconnected from the neighborhood it's plopped down in. That's sometimes how it goes with deals like this. So I'm skeptical of the way that new stadium deals come about. There's all this fraught negotiation, all the upended neighborhoods, all the broken promises about revitalizing the local economy.

All for what, at times, can feel like a billionaire owner's shiny new toy. A new stadium deal can be the crowning achievement for a mayor or a city council, and it's a product of our obsession with our home teams. But do we need to ask what school or park or roads didn't we fund in order to build this thing?

In a stadium deal, you get this little microcosm of lots of other things: a vision for a city's future, a sense of how that city will prioritize its investments, of what a community's leaders truly value and where they are willing to compromise, what's responsible, and what's ethical. And you should know when David Sampson is in the room, all those big questions—what's ethical—they don't matter.

[00:04:23] David Samson: "What should we do here ethically?" never, ever comes up when you're negotiating a stadium deal.

[00:04:31] Jody Avirgan: My name is Jody Avirgan. And this is Good Sport from the TED Audio Collective. On this episode, we ask: is there such a thing as a good stadium?

[BREAK]

[00:04:56] Jody Avirgan: If you're trying to figure out how someone convinces local politicians to spend taxpayer dollars on a home plate fish tank, Andrew Zimbalist can help. Zimbalist is Professor Emeritus at Smith College who focuses on the economics of sports, and when I spoke with him, he gave me a checklist of how to evaluate a stadium deal.

Andrew likes to start with the big numbers on the deal, total cost, and the balance: how much the owner is paying versus how much the community is shelling out.

[00:05:25] Andrew Zimbalist: What's the amount that's being invested of public money at the end of the day to enrich, uh, a private owner of a sports team?

[00:05:33] Jody Avirgan: These days, lots of owners are billionaires or even multi-billionaires. So yes, a team is expensive, but for many of them, it's just another investment, another item in the portfolio. But on a new stadium, these billionaires still want to turn a profit as quickly as possible, so they ask for subsidies to get the thing built.

[00:05:55] Andrew Zimbalist: How much does the city have to put out? And that has to do with the, the leverage that the owners have. And it's an interesting economic question. How do you parse those two elements out? How much should the subsidy be?

[00:06:08] Jody Avirgan: There are lots of different subsidies that can cover the cost of a massive new ballpark. One of the big upfront costs is the land; stadiums use lots of it. Occasionally, an owner will buy the land for a stadium, but often the land, which mind you might be used to build something like a school or a park, that land is seen as something the city needs to subsidize to get the deal done.

[00:06:31] Andrew Zimbalist: It's possible that the city will turn over 30 acres of land to, to the ballpark and not charge anything for it. Or if they charge something for it, they won't charge the, the full value for it.

[00:06:43] Jody Avirgan: Another thing to look at: taxes. How much of a tax break does the city include? The city isn't negotiating with you or me on our taxes, but they certainly are with a sports owner.

[00:06:53] Andrew Zimbalist: Is there a tax? Is there a sales tax? Is there a property tax that the team has to pay?

[00:06:58] Jody Avirgan: The next big question: what else might exist on this land besides the stadium? Because in most cities, space is limited.

[00:07:07] Andrew Zimbalist: If you're gonna give 20 or 30 acres of land over to the development of a stadium, does that mean that you can't build a new school that you need? Does it mean that you can't build a new city hall that you need? Does it mean you can't build low-income or middle-income housing that you need?

[00:07:20] Jody Avirgan: When I go back and visit someplace I used to live, like all of us, I notice. I notice what's new. I notice what's not. There's often new apartment buildings, but maybe I'll also notice the same park playground I played on when I was a kid. The chain on the swing a little rustier, or the same housing development that looks 10 years older, 10 years more rundown. And often, in many cities, when I'm visiting, I'm driving around and yep, there it is. A brand new stadium. All of these, the school playground, the housing development, the stadium, they're choices, decisions. Ones our elected officials made. Deals they cut in some room somewhere.

I think a lot of the frustration there is that it comes down to, uh, as these deals often come down to, you know, a five-person commission and the one swing vote on that commission, and it's really about how do we get that person to vote for this deal, and it feels like the public is cut out of this.

[00:08:19] Andrew Zimbalist: Yeah, well, welcome to America. It's not surprising to see political practices reproduced throughout the economy, throughout the society. It's not surprising to see the class structure reproduced by these deals. It's not surprising to see deals where wealthy people become wealthier, uh, it happens everywhere.

[00:08:41] Jody Avirgan: That's why I wanted to talk to David Samson, the guy who was the agent for the rich Miami owner, the one brokering the deal that would make that owner even richer. The guy who says ethics are never a consideration when you negotiate a stadium. Who the heck is this guy?

[00:08:59] David Samson: My name is David Samson, and I am 54 years old. I started my career as just a tiny little boy in elementary school. No, that's not true. I was not Doogie Hauser. I was a baby. I had diapers on.

[00:09:14] Jody Avirgan: You should know, and you can probably tell already, David tends to exaggerate, but I don't think anyone who is part of these deals is gonna give you, like, a

100% unbiased account. And David was in those rooms. So, I do think he's worth listening to.

[00:09:29] David Samson: At the end of the day when it was down to the “are we in or are we out?” it was me and just two other people on the other side.

[00:09:36] Jody Avirgan: So we're talking about literally three men in a room.

[00:09:40] David Samson: It's three men and a baby. That's pretty much what it was.

[00:09:47] Jody Avirgan: There were logical reasons why the Marlins would benefit from a new stadium. They were sharing the old stadium with the football team, the Dolphins, and it really did make sense to have a new stadium where they could close the roof during rain, which the previous stadium didn't have. Otherwise, they'd have to keep canceling and rescheduling home games. But the most useful tool in a negotiation like this isn't logic, it's emotion.

[00:10:10] David Samson: Anytime you are talking to someone, you are negotiating with that person. You are trying to convey something to them. You're trying to get them to understand what you want or to do what you want or to do what they think they want, but it's really what you want. But when someone is negotiating who is emotional, you've already won. It's over.

[00:10:31] Jody Avirgan: And people get emotional about sports stadiums. There's a sense of civic pride with your local sports team and a sense of loss if they leave. Just ask old timers in Baltimore who still remember when the Colts skipped town in the dead of night or basketball fans in Seattle who lost their beloved franchise to Oklahoma City.

[00:10:50] David Samson: It's the reason why these deals keep happening, because the politicians do not want to be responsible when a team leaves a city. They don't want to be responsible for anything negative associated with that professional sports team. And there's that emotional pull that you can tug on and you win every deal.

[00:11:10] Jody Avirgan: And so you're saying that the owners and the people negotiating on their behalf, they know that. They know they have that leverage.

[00:11:19] David Samson: A hundred percent every time.

[00:11:21] Jody Avirgan: The very thing that makes sports special—the emotions, the pride—it's what David exploited in his negotiation. He tugged on that by making it seem like Miami really could lose the Marlins.

[00:11:34] David Samson: I hate to not give myself credit because it's sort of cool what I did, but the reason anyone could have done it is that I knew and everyone knew that there was no way that Miami was going to let the Marlins leave Miami.

[00:11:47] Jody Avirgan: That threat or negotiating tactic—“We'll, we'll leave.” I'm always curious kind of how real that threat is. Sometimes it feels to me like a threat that, you know, is just, uh, gonna be a useful threat, but it's not really a possibility.

[00:12:00] David Samson: Well, again, go back to your conversations that I call negotiations. How often do you say something where you say to yourself, “There's no way I'm gonna allow that to happen, but I'm gonna say it and I'm gonna say it hoping that the other person believes what I'm saying and will act accordingly”?

[00:12:16] Jody Avirgan: David wouldn't call it a bluff, but I will. And to make it believable, he flew to San Antonio. He met with city officials there. Did they want the Marlins? Were they willing to build them a shiny new stadium? His performance made the threat seem real. And people in Miami noticed; they started to think, “Wow, we could really lose the Marlins.”

[00:12:38] David Samson: Franchises use other cities as leverage, period. And the only people who don't realize it are the people who run the cities.

[00:12:46] Jody Avirgan: And it worked because a politician is probably not gonna lose their job over a few schools closing. But lose the home team? Your career is over. And that

means when it comes to these negotiations, team owners can ask the city for a lot of help. The magic number for a stadium deal is as much as team owners dare ask for. A billionaire sports team owner will just turn to a city and ask for help when, I don't know, maybe they could just pay for the stadium their own damn selves.

Or maybe I should put it this way. Billionaire owners hold so much power in these negotiations that their ask for the stadium, the tax breaks, the land lease, it comes to be seen as normal, expected even. But if you just take a step back, at least from my point of view, and from a lot of Miamians' point of view, a deal like this is insane.

350 million dollars in taxpayer money, eventually ballooning to 2 billion? In David's point of view, there's no taking a step back. Up close and in the room, he saw this as a middle-of-the-road stadium deal; he maybe thinks he could have asked for more.

[00:13:56] David Samson: The reputation is that the stadium deal in Miami was very one-sided. But the irony is when that deal was cut and approved, there were many owners angry with us because they thought the deal was far too government-friendly and not team friendly enough.

[00:14:13] Jody Avirgan: Right. But measuring the response of fellow owners isn't the only way to gauge response to a deal.

[00:14:20] David Samson: It's the only way that I care to gauge it, right? Because those are the people I'm competing with. You bring up the best point. When I run a baseball team, I'm competing with the 29 other teams and what they're willing to pay a player. I don't care about fan bases. I don't care about the media. I don't care about fans, right? That's not my job. I'm not competing with the fan base in St. Louis. I'm competing with the owners in St. Louis and the president of the St. Louis Cardinals. I need to make smarter signs, make better deals, so I have a competitive advantage.

[00:14:49] Jody Avirgan: There's no, there's no thought of the public in that room when you get down to it?

[00:14:54] David Samson: The answer is that fans and Miamians, uh, the subject never came up.

[00:14:59] Jody Avirgan: Since David didn't listen to Miamians, allow me to pick a few choice examples of their outrage. The Miami New Times called the stadium, a quote, "festering silver plated pustule", "a grotesquely huge can opener", or "just an obscene ode to wasted cash". In Bleacher Report, they said Marlins Park represents a perfect example of how not to build a publicly funded stadium. I don't think David saw those headlines.

[00:15:24] David Samson: There could be people protesting. There could be people taking ads out in the paper, people suing me. There could be anything, and it didn't matter. I needed certain votes in a commission. That is politics. That is what representation is. Don't complain to me about what the politicians are doing, who are voted into office by those who do vote.

[00:15:42] Jody Avirgan: What was it that Andrew Zimbalist said? Yeah, welcome to America. These deals, they're just gonna reflect larger power dynamics, democracy in action. In 2017, former baseball great Derek Jeter bought the Marlins, and he fired David Samson. Samson's career as a baseball president was over, so he did what people do when they leave the sport: he's become a commentator. He has a podcast where he shares his takes on just about everything when it comes to the business of sports.

[00:16:13] David Samson: My head has changed to education. I think one of the ways that I was able to operate for 18 years is that it was important that the majority of people were in the dark.

[00:16:22] Jody Avirgan: To me anyway, it seems like he is genuinely trying to decode the business of sports for regular people. I wouldn't call him a whistleblower, but sort of a master of the dark arts who's now willing to share the secrets of how billions of dollars get moved from taxpayers to owners. David talks about stadium deals on his show. Most recently, he's been weighing in on a contentious deal in Miami over a soccer development. That one included even more egregious giveaways to developers. David's one of the few people willing to actually go there.

[00:16:53] David Samson: You're not gonna get a current team president to talk about stadium financing because we would never do this.

[00:16:58] Jody Avirgan: Yeah.

[00:16:58] David Samson: Because we would never want you to think that there's even an inch of give. And so I, I take pretty seriously the responsibility I have. It's not a crisis of conscience at all. I, I very much agree with everything I did when I was president, and I wouldn't do anything differently. So I don't have a crisis of conscience. I'm just in a different place in my life now.

[00:17:18] Jody Avirgan: When someone tells you twice in 30 seconds that they aren't suffering from a crisis of conscience, I suppose you have to believe them. There's no change of heart there. There's no regrets. So, what might change if there's a little more transparency?

[00:17:31] David Samson: You deserve to know what's happening, but it's not gonna change the outcome. And you may call me cynical on that, but politicians and owners of sports teams or owners of companies who want to do business in a particular city, we still have ways to get stuff done that you just, you just wouldn't understand even if you read it.

[00:17:49] Jody Avirgan: But you saying that the kind of transparency that you value and that you're advocating for wouldn't actually change an outcome.

[00:17:56] David Samson: It would not.

[00:17:57] Jody Avirgan: Um, so what are we talking about here?

[00:18:00] David Samson: We're talking about trying to make people feel better about their lot in life. I'm talking about education. I'm talking about at least having knowledge of what's happening to you while it's happening, and if you want to go into politics and try to make changes, then do that. If you wanna go into business and try to make changes and do things differently, then do that.

[00:18:21] Jody Avirgan: That is a pretty bleak outlook, right? David's saying we need more transparency. At the same time, he's saying that's not really gonna be enough to flip a negotiation. But I don't know. I feel like there must be at least one example of a stadium deal gone right.

Or if not right, then at least better. Or one that reflects a more interesting way of thinking about these things. One where people felt included in the process and reached some larger benefit once it was all said and done. There has to be something we can look for for hope, and I couldn't have been more surprised where I maybe found the answer.

[BREAK]

[00:19:13] Jody Avirgan: Before I started working on this episode, I was eager and curious to see what a good stadium deal might look like. I figured it would come down to subsidy levels or givebacks to the community. A lot of stuff in the real weeds of how these deals go down. And when I spoke with the economist Andrew Zimbalist, I asked him if he could think of a place where it felt like the deal was at least neutral, if not beneficial to a city. He named a few recent sports stadiums here in the US that were built with a little more public input where the land was purchased outright. But I still wanted to know if there was

anything that felt like more expansive thinking, that broke out of that three men-in-a-room approach. I was surprised when he mentioned this:

[00:19:56] Andrew Zimbalist: Another interesting example in my mind with the Olympics is Barcelona in 1992.

[00:20:01] Jody Avirgan: The Olympics, the mother of all sports boondoggles. I kind of couldn't believe what I was hearing. Sure, hosting the Olympics is a different animal than building a single stadium in one city, but many of the big questions are the same. What are we getting? What are we giving up? Is sports being put ahead of other priorities? What kind of people are we cutting deals with to make this happen? In these days, I think many people feel like hosting the Olympics can be a truly raw deal. I've seen so many photos of Olympic stadiums left abandoned, overgrown, sometimes just 10 years after the big event.

There's been cities that have pushed back against the Olympics—Colorado and Boston, for example—because they just don't think it makes financial sense. But not Barcelona, not in 1992. Barcelona made the Olympics work for them.

[00:20:51] Andrew Zimbalist: Some people said, "Hey, we could host the Olympics and, and have the Olympic requirements facilitate the changes we're making." Uh, and that's how it worked out. They used the Olympics to facilitate and help finance the plan that they laid for their city.

[00:21:09] Jody Avirgan: What was the secret?

[00:21:13] Mirela Fiori: Vale. A ver...

[00:21:13] Jody Avirgan: So I called someone in Barcelona.

[00:21:14] Mirela Fiori: Esta un auricular por aquí...

[00:21:16] Jody Avirgan: Qué bueno. Y, y lo quieres decir en español, también, "Mi nombre es..." y decirlo otra vez para... ¿Sí? Dile.

[00:21:22] Mirela Fiori: Sí. Mi nombre es Mirela Fiori. Soy directora del Máster universitario de Ciudad y Urbanismo de la Universitat Oberta de Catalunya. Trabajando...

[00:21:31] Jody Avirgan: Mirela Fiori is the director of the Master's program in Urbanism at the University of Cataluña. And she thinks that the Barcelona Olympics truly transformed the city for the better, beyond just the sports facilities and in ways that are still felt today. Barcelona's leaders did this by working the Olympics and the money that comes from hosting the Olympics into an already existing vision for the city's revitalization.

The story begins about 20 years earlier in the early seventies when Spain was climbing out from under the dictatorship of Francisco Franco. Out of decades of political and cultural repression.

[00:22:11] Mirela Fiori: Desde antes de que se mu—se muriera Franco...

[00:22:13] Mirela Fiori (Translator - Constanza Gallardo): Before Franco died, there was already an important neighborhood grassroots movement, a movement obviously against the dictatorship. In 1972, the Federation of Neighborhood Associations was created here in Barcelona, and it built on the already existing neighborhood movement struggling for better conditions. So when Franco died, a period of transition began.

[00:22:40] Jody Avirgan: Barcelona's neighborhoods were fighting for local change. The Federation of Neighborhood Associations asked for the kind of improvements you might expect. They wanted paved streets. They wanted traffic lights. They wanted trash pickup. And the advocacy that these neighborhood associations did established a process and an expectation that government would respond to local demands.

So, when Barcelona embarked on a massive development plan in the wake of Franco, the neighborhoods were involved. It wasn't always an easy conversation, but the neighborhoods had a voice and a vision about connecting different parts of the city.

[00:23:17] Mirela Fiori: Pero evidentemente, no? Que para situar de Barcelona para...

[00:23:22] Mirela Fiori (Translator): They had a vision to position Barcelona as the center of a great region, and for this, it was most important to open the sea and build infrastructure to set up the neighborhoods.

[00:23:35] Jody Avirgan: Barcelona's city planners wanted to move the manufacturing away from the waterfront and make the beaches friendlier to tourism.

They wanted to rework the highways to make it easier to get around the city. And at some point, the planners had a kind of genius idea. They would put in a bid to host the Olympics. Cities often wanna host the Olympics because of pride or because they think it might boost tourism, and it can. Barcelona wanted those things too, but maybe unlike other places, Barcelona also kept in mind their larger urban development plan.

The Olympics could help. They could build stadiums for the Olympics, sure. But they could also use the money that would come in from the Olympics to cover some other infrastructure projects. Projects that both served the Olympics and their longer-term goals for revitalizing the city. It would be expensive, but instead of one-time-use stadiums, they were building structures they planned to use for years and decades to come.

Mirela says that the neighborhood associations influenced this planning. Not every demand was met. These are negotiations. There's trade-off. People will be disappointed, but the neighborhood associations were in the room, so to speak. And if you ask me, that's what makes the difference.

[00:24:11] Mirela Fiori: Los gobiernos de, de proximidad son los que pueden recoger...

[00:24:48] Mirela Fiori (Translator): These local governments were able to better recognize the city's demands because they were there in that place from the larger population. And this, I believe, was important because it reinforced the principles of Democratic government.

[00:25:09] Jody Avirgan: To hear Mirela describe it, post-Franco Barcelona kind of feels like what we imagine when we think of the democratic process. The public working together with their local representatives, calling them out when needed, keeping them accountable. I'll say it; I was in Barcelona recently and you know, just in my time there, I did notice some of this. The waterfront, it feels vibrant. The neighborhoods in the city feel connected, but also unique. It's been 30 years. Obviously, lots has changed, but people still brought up the Olympics when I talked to them about their city.

[00:25:44] Mirela Fiori: La transformación de Barcelona continua, sigue transformándose desde...

[00:25:44] Mirela Fiori (Translator): Barcelona continues to transform itself and has changed all this time, but the period of change starts with the Olympic Games. That was a great contribution. This has been really valuable for the city.

[00:26:05] Jody Avirgan: Okay, so what have we learned? The key to a productive sports development deal is to suffer under dictatorship for more than 30 years, have a populace open to community-level socialism, have the Olympics come along at just the right time. Are you taking notes? This is the plan. No. Look for real. That's not gonna happen everywhere. This is a very different era in a very different country. There are no tidy answers here, but there are some things to keep in mind the next time you hear about a new stadium proposal. For one, remember that the deals are being cut by guys like David Samson in that room on behalf of billionaire owners.

Now that you've spent some time with him, how does that make you feel? Does it seem like the system is maybe a little tilted in their favor, just a bit? And so what are you gonna do about it? How can you make it so that the right elected officials are sitting in that room across from David Samson, ones who aren't afraid to piss off a developer, ones who feel accountable to you and your value?

Well, I, for one, am going to remember what David Samson told me. Stadium deals are emotional. He thinks that works to his advantage, but I think it can work in the other direction too. These things are emotional, and if you care not just about sports, but about your city and your community and how it spends hundreds of millions of dollars, maybe ballooning to billions of dollars, then get emotional about this.

Realize that a stadium deal is this perfect encapsulation of our democracy, and that's something worth fighting for and paying attention to by voting, by agitating, by showing up at the city council meeting on a Tuesday night to ask for the school or the park to be put in line ahead of the stadium. We can do these things, and if the owner is still not listening, tell them to build their own damn stadium.

On the next episode of Good Sport:

[00:28:04] Jess Smetana: I'm still surprised with myself how much I've gotten into Formula One.

[00:28:09] Jody Avirgan: How a docu-series on Netflix cemented a motorsport into American fandom. What does it mean to grab our attention when there's more competition than ever? Good Sport is brought to you by the TED Audio Collective. It's hosted by me, Jody Avirgan, and the show is produced by TED. This episode was written and produced by Poncie Rutsch. Our team includes Isabel Carter, Camille Peterson, Sarah Nics, Jimmy Gutierrez, Michelle Quint, BanBan Cheng, and Roxanne Hai Lash. Jake Gorski is our sound designer and mix engineer. Special thanks to Constanza Gallardo for voicing the translations in this episode.

Fact-checking by Dianna Bautista and Julia Dickerson. Thanks again to Andrew Zimbalist. He's written many great books about the business of sports. Check 'em out. And for more David Samson, check out his podcast, Nothing Personal. If you have questions or comments about this episode or anything at all, be in touch. Our email is goodsport@ted.com.

Also, if you enjoyed this episode, here's an idea: go to your podcast app, click "Share", and text it to a friend. Even better—text it to a friend who may not think that they would listen to a sports podcast, but they might listen to this one. You never know. Thanks again for listening to Good Sport. My name is Jody Avirgan, and we'll see you soon.

How to Make a Fan: From F1 to Banana Ball (Transcript)

Listen along

Good Sport How to Make a Fan: From F1 to Banana Ball

March 8, 2023

[00:00:00] Jess Smetana: I'm still surprised with myself how much I've gotten into Formula 1.

[00:00:06] Jody Avirgan: Up until a couple years ago, Jessica Smetana didn't know anything about Formula 1.

[00:00:14] Jess Smetana: I've never been a fan of NASCAR, IndyCar, any other sort of motorsport. I didn't even know what a tire

rotation was until three years ago. I thought that just meant they, like, put your car up on a spike and spin the wheels around for 10 minutes and then put it back down and you drive away.

[00:00:29] Jody Avirgan: Jessica is a sports journalist and a podcaster, and no one is more surprised than her that one of the shows she now hosts is a Formula 1 podcast. It's called DNF, short for Did Not Finish.

[00:00:43] Jess Smetana: It's still a little surreal because I've always liked the same sports since I was five years old. You know, football, basketball, hockey, baseball, soccer, tennis. That's pretty much it.

[00:00:57] Jody Avirgan: This picture that Jess is painting, it's pretty familiar, right? The sports we watch, they're often the sports that are with us as kids. We played basketball growing up or we went to a game with a parent and then boom, we are adults and we are diehard NBA fans, and those sports that Jessica rattled off—football, basketball, baseball, et cetera—that's kind of the list.

That's who's sitting at the table. So how does a racecar driver with great hair and a hard-to-place European accent find a seat at Jessica's table? How does a sports fan suddenly find an entirely new passion in a sport she's never had any interest in? It's all thanks to a little series on Netflix called Formula 1: Drive To Survive.

Every season of the show covers a racing year of Formula 1, and the episodes are part recap, part explainer, part character drama. You get the full rundown of what Formula 1 is. It's a motorsport. The cars are carefully engineered for top speed. You meet the engineering teams; you meet the drivers.

You see them trying to execute crazy passes or, in the case of one driver, finding himself enveloped in flames after a crash. He survived, by the way. Don't worry. Some of the racetracks are set up downtown in cities like Monaco and Baku twisting and turning between skyscrapers and seaside views.

"Formula 1: the TV series" captured Americans' attention in a way that "Formula 1: the sport" had never managed. The sport has been popular for a long time in other parts of the world. Europe mostly, but not in the US until Drive to Survive got people hooked. The Netflix series was a hit. The 2022 racing season averaged 50% more viewers than the previous season, which was already the most-watched F1 season ever in the US.

And this is unusual because with TV programs and streaming platforms and apps and everything else competing for your attention, the media ecosystem is disintegrating, fracturing. Most places are worried about losing audience. Sports is often seen as immune to those pressures, but even in sports, just treading water, not losing audience, is seen as a win. So to really break through, that's tough.

[MUSIC BREAK]

[00:03:24] Jody Avirgan: My name is Jody Avirgan, and this is Good Sport from the TED Audio Collective. On this episode, we're looking at two examples of sports that did the unthinkable. They broke through and captured the attention of a massive number of people, and maybe this marketing-first approach is changing the very nature of how we watch and play sports.

[BREAK]

[00:04:03] Jody Avirgan: Formula 1 has been around for more than 70 years, doing just fine, thank you, in the European market. But the idea for Drive to Survive came when an American media company bought the motorsport.

[00:04:15] Jess Smetana: You have to give credit to Liberty Media, which bought Formula 1 in 2017 and made a decided push to market Formula 1 to the United States.

[00:04:24] Jody Avirgan: Liberty Media is a giant media conglomerate. They own the Atlanta Braves, but mostly they own entertainment companies like SiriusXM and Live Nation. They once owned Starz. I think they once had a controlling stake in court TV and even the

McNeil/Lehrer news hour. I don't know. I kind of got lost with all the mergers and spinoffs. The point is: they're enormous and their main business seems to be eyeballs. Wherever they can find them.

[00:04:49] Spencer Hall: They knew they were sitting on top of, uh, an unclaimed territory of followers, right? And potential new fans.

[00:04:56] Jody Avirgan: Spencer Hall co-hosts DNF with Jessica Smetana, and he says that if F1's new ownership wanted to grow the sport, they needed to identify where they might find new fans who might watch Formula 1 if they just knew a little bit more about it.

[00:05:13] Spencer Hall: Where's F1 going to expand? Is F1 gonna find new viewers in England? Right? Are they going to, are they going to expand the Belgian market? No. They're pretty much, like, full up there. So even just getting a small toehold in America represents a tremendous gain for them.

[00:05:28] Jody Avirgan: And for Liberty Media, F1's new owners, why not try what they know? Make entertainment. So when someone suggests they follow a racing team, just film a bunch of behind-the-scenes content, it escalates. Liberty Media reaches out to a production company; they end up pitching a docu-series. One year later, they're filming the entire 2018 racing season for what would become the first season of Drive to Survive. The show went live on Netflix in March of 2019.

[00:05:56] Spencer Hall: It did what I think every sort of great form of storytelling does, which is it focused on characters more so than the outcomes. They didn't have access to the best teams, but they made drama out of who they could talk to. And it just so happens if you do that and combine it with cars that go 200 miles an hour and can drive on the top of the Monte Carlo tunnel, that's a pretty compelling product.

[00:06:19] Jody Avirgan: Yes, you heard Spencer correctly. The top of a tunnel in Monaco. F1 fans love to argue about whether a Formula 1 car could drive so fast that it could ride upside down along the ceiling of a tunnel. It's never actually happened, but folks like to speculate whether it's possible. It's the kind of factoid you might not pick up on if you just tuned in to watch a race; you might only see cars going round and round and flip the channel. But if you've seen Drive to Survive, you understand what you're seeing. You have some backstory. They've translated the sport for you and walked you right up to the edge of real-life fandom.

[00:06:55] Spencer Hall: There's a lot of teaching you how to watch a race involved in Drive to Survive; if you'd never watched a race before, you can pick out the cruxes, you can pick out the, the points of trauma. Like, our tires aren't working right. Like the driver is sick, right? It's hot, it's cold, it's rainy, whatever. You could pick out a real basic how-to-watch from just watching Drive to Survive.

[00:07:16] Jody Avirgan: Spencer thinks of this as fan onboarding, and he says you have to be kind of subtle. You don't wanna over-explain.

[00:07:23] Spencer Hall: Like they need to think like a video game designer. They need to go, "How do I teach you how to press A, press B, and to uh, look around with the joystick, right? Without really being overt about it."

[00:07:35] Jody Avirgan: Yeah.

[00:07:35] Spencer Hall: Most of the time people do not understand the basic mechanics of the sport and that's okay. That's what sport—like, it's not a spectacle unless it can attract you with no prior knowledge, right? Which F1 can do 'cause it's loud and it's fast and things go vroom.

[00:07:50] Jody Avirgan: Of course, the timing of Drive to Survive didn't hurt either. Season two, the one that really took off, dropped on February 28th, 2020.

[00:08:03] Jess Smetana: I was sitting home doing nothing like, you know, no sports going on, pandemic. I've already baked every type of bread. And my boyfriend asked if we could put it on. And by the second episode, I was screaming at my television. I didn't know what I was watching, but I knew that I loved all the characters.

[00:08:21] Jody Avirgan: It's funny, Jess, your, your point about baking bread. I just had this memory pop into my head of like three days into lockdown, I made sun tea and I'd like never made sun tea before. And I don't think I consciously even realized I was making sun tea. I just looked up and there was sun tea, and I was like, "Oh, somewhere deep inside me is like the hippie waiting to make sun tea." But then watching, you know, watching everything right when it pops up in front of you. And I mean, to me, like that is a huge part of this story.

[00:08:51] Jess Smetana: I think there are a lot of TV phenomenons we experienced in the US during the pandemic, like the last dance documentary or the Tiger King Netflix series that were kind of flash in the pan moments, whereas Drive to Survive maybe outlasted the initial shutdown period.

[00:09:09] Jody Avirgan: Let me just say, I think the pandemic explains so many things. I am baffled when I see any reporting or analysis about almost any phenomenon these days that doesn't lead with the pandemic, from politics to the economy to race and culture and work-life. It seems to me that any take should at least start with the fact that, you know, there's been this grinding global pandemic for, like three, years.

So yeah, I think the pandemic must have been a huge factor here. People were discovering the series in Spring 2020, and they were all talking about it, building a community of fans, 'cause what else were we gonna do stuck in our houses?

[00:09:45] Jess Smetana: I also thought one of the appeals was the international appeal of drivers being from different countries.

[00:09:51] Jody Avirgan: Yeah.

[00:09:51] Jess Smetana: And teams being based in different countries and races being all over the world. It felt like I was simultaneously watching sports, but also maybe a mini, mini travel documentary.

[00:10:00] Spencer Hall: Yeah. It's, uh, the, the Rick Steves motorsport.

[00:10:02] Jody Avirgan: Jess and Spencer say that once people discovered Drive to Survive and were properly onboarded, what really hooked them—the thing that Liberty Media was putting front and center—were the characters, stakes, and storylines.

[00:10:17] Jess Smetana: My co-host on my, another show that I do, Kate Fagan gave a TED Boston talk, I think. It was where she was explaining that the reason that we fall in love with sports are the stakes and the storylines.

[00:10:28] Kate Fagan: This is what burns at the center of sports. In the Olympics, we have all agreed a gold medal matters. Same with the World Cup. And now paired with this agreed-upon stakes, we also have even deeper storytelling. Which is how we end up teary-eyed after a three-and-a-half minute NBC vignette about a Romanian gymnast.

[00:11:00] Jody Avirgan: But here's where I'm a little more skeptical. Hooking someone on stakes and storylines might engage them for a few minutes or a few weeks, but does it always translate to long-term passion? Like, I don't watch competitive curling outside of the Winter Olympics. I'm just an expert on curling strategy for like two weeks every four years, and then I go, "See you in four years, Niklas Edin of Sweden. Good luck in your quest to be the only skip to win four Olympic medals."

And then I move on. In fact, this disconnect between entertainment and actual viewership has started happening for me in other sports. I watch the HBO series Hard Knocks every season. I love it. Full of stakes, full of storylines. But I gave up watching actual NFL football

years ago, and no matter how good Hard Knocks is, I'm not finding my way back to the actual games.

And this is where I think I'm at with F1. Sure. Drive through Survive is great TV, especially for those of us stuck inside, sipping our sun tea, having already watched every season of the Great British Bake-Off. If I'm being particularly cruel, I would maybe argue that F1 is like the Bored Ape NFT of sports.

In two years, will we all look back and say, "I can't believe I spent my time and money on that?" And if Drive to Survive doesn't create actual in-the-flesh fans, then for Liberty Media, why bother? Or maybe, the Netflix audience is the point. It's a little murky. Jess and Spencer, they think I'm overthinking it because the way they see it, Drive to Survive is clearly the gateway to watching F1 events live and going to the races.

[00:12:38] Jess Smetana: Yeah, I wanna make it clear, because we've talked a lot about characters and storylines—

[00:12:43] Jody Avirgan: Yeah.

[00:12:43] Jess Smetana: —and different drivers and all of these things. But the sporting aspect of Formula 1 is awesome.

[00:12:50] Jody Avirgan: Yeah.

[00:12:51] Jess Smetana: It is so much fun to watch. It's competitive, exciting. It's fast. It's fun. It changes location to location. There's strategies involved. There's so much to debate. It has all of the things that we love about all the sports that are already extremely popular in the US. So, the way that I think a lot of people got hooked into it was through the non-sporting elements, and then maybe you stuck around and watched a race and realized, "Holy shit, this is awesome. I'm gonna keep watching these 'cause it's really fun."

[00:13:19] Jody Avirgan: Another thing that leads to sustainability, and I love this one, the time that it airs.

[00:13:25] Spencer Hall: Generally speaking, the times vary. It pops in on Sundays before football. You're gonna be able to watch them before American sports kick in. That means instead of spending half the day on the couch watching sports, I can spend the entire day on the couch watching sports.

[00:13:40] Jody Avirgan: It sells itself!

[00:13:41] Spencer Hall: Sometimes before everyone else gets up, it's ideal.

[00:13:45] Jody Avirgan: Yeah.

[00:13:45] Spencer Hall: I think people also, once they began watching the races, discovered a great advantage to many Euro sports, which is that they really do not like to go longer than two hours. It's compact. Well, if I'm watching a NASCAR race, it could be four hours. If F1, there are limits. They're like, "No, we can't take longer than two hours to finish this race."

[00:14:07] Jody Avirgan: Honestly, I think this is huge. I've always had this theory that one of the big reasons Premier League soccer took off in this country is because of the timeslot. Same thing: weekend mornings when there isn't anything else on, people are around looking for something to watch and hey, there it is on TV.

I'll take it a step further. If I was designing a new sport to break through, I might start with the time slot. Who cares what the sport is? Just be on at the right time. You know what, I've got my eye on? Tuesday nights, Tuesday night. Be honest, if you were bored on a Tuesday night and ESPN-2 was airing Tuesday night Frisbee starring washed-up handler Jody Avirgan hanging on for one last season of glory, you'd watch it, right? You'd watch it. You would. Anyway, back on track. If Drive to Survive has helped F1 get a little toehold in the attention economy, they are now monetizing the heck out of it.

[00:14:59] Jess Smetana: I think what comes next for Formula 1 will be interesting because they've gotten the bigger media rights investment from ESPN. The media rights now are, I think, 75 million dollars, whereas before they were paying 5 million.

[00:15:11] Jody Avirgan: And there was a massive bidding war, right? I mean...

[00:15:12] Jess Smetana: Yeah. And they stuck with ESPN, and they also wanna grow and they wanna go where the money is. And right now all the money is in the United States. I heard during the Miami Grand Prix week that Formula 1 was amazed at how in the United States you can slap a brand on anything; they could sell so much.

[00:15:30] Spencer Hall: You're absolutely right. The number of experiences that you can roll up and have at an F1 race if you have the money. You can get track passes. You can get a ride along with an actual driver.

[00:15:42] Jody Avirgan: It doesn't matter if only a fraction of Drive to Survive viewers become Formula 1 diehards because F1 can extract all this money from just a few fans. It's kind of protection if attention levels were to drop off.

[00:15:58] Spencer Hall: Eventually, American interest will plateau, but once you get that, F1's gonna be able to live off that market with a spectrum of experiences, gear, merch, memberships, like what does the NFL offer a fan in terms of an experience? Nothing, like you get a free hotdog and a drink in a box. That's about it.

[00:16:19] Jess Smetana: Some guy in the back row puking on you.

[00:16:20] Spencer Hall: Right. Imagine if your ticket dynamic, every race was the Super Bowl. That's kind of what we're looking at.

[00:16:33] Jody Avirgan: Hm. So I do think I'm convinced: Formula 1 has set itself up really nicely. Perhaps it's not gonna be as massive as other sports in the US, but maybe we can think of it as a boutique sport. Let's say it's sitting at the table of fandom next to tennis. And unlike some of these other sports, it now has this bonus audience that streams a new season of Drive to Survive every year for as long as that show might run, or at least until there's a new season of Tiger King.

No surprise, lots of other people are trying to tap into the same success that F1 has found. There are a gazillion sports documentary imitators out there, and some of them are moving the needle. There's this one show, Welcome to Wrexham, where two celebrities buy a struggling Welsh soccer club. The show has drama and characters, of course, and at moments, the two celebrity owners ask themselves the same question that we're asking here, whether it's authentic and sustainable to buy a team and use a docu-series to bolster a club's fortune.

But, like, that's what the docu-series is about. So it goes round and round. It's like marketing about marketing. It's very weird. I stopped after four episodes. And yet a month into the show, the club reported a 20% increase in followers on social media. Their retail and merchandise sales brought in more than five times what they'd done the year before.

So like it or not, that is the attention economy formula. It worked for F1, and it's working for other sports. But what if you're trying to grow a team that happens to play a sport that's not trying to break through, but one that has been around for centuries, one that is suffering from a crisis of boringness? Up next, let's play ball: Banana style.

[BREAK]

[00:18:29] Jody Avirgan: A long time ago, I spent a summer working as a cameraman for a minor-league baseball team called the Savannah Sand Gnats. I got the job because a guy I met in a park told me that they needed a cameraman. I told him I was a film major and he was like, "Okay, show up at the ballpark tomorrow." I did. I had no idea what I was doing.

The games were hot and long. I bet you like 10 people watched. But I got paid in chicken fingers and unlimited soda refills. Now, in every possible sense, that was a long time ago. These days, down in Savannah, things are very different. In 2015, a guy named Jesse Cole bought the Sand Gnats, and over the years he has changed a ton about the team's marketing strategy, how they grow their fan base, even the rules of the game, which we'll get into. But the first thing he changed was that name.

[00:19:18] Jesse Cole: I'll never forget February 25th, 2016. So that, that's when we named the team the Bananas.

[00:19:23] Jody Avirgan: When I interviewed Jesse, he was wearing his signature yellow tuxedo and was carrying his yellow bowler hat. I wouldn't be surprised if the guy even sleeps in yellow pajamas. Everything Jesse does with the Savannah Bananas, he does over the top, and the name switch wasn't his only big idea when he took over the team.

[00:19:41] Jesse Cole: We said we could have a senior citizen dance team called the Banana Nanas. You know, we could have a male cheerleading team called The Man-Nanas. We could have a break dancing coach, a banana baby that we lift up every game, have our players do dances, and make it fun.

[00:19:52] Jody Avirgan: Those are some pretty big changes in a pretty traditionalist sport. And no surprise, they got tons of pushback.

[00:20:00] Jesse Cole: We got ripped apart. "Whoever came up with this name should be fired. You're an embarrassment to the city. You'll never sell a, a ticket." I mean, "the owners should be thrown outta town." I mean, we were ripped apart.

And then it became a conversation. "I like the name. I hate the name. I like the name. I hate the name." And when you create conversation, then you can get legs to any type of campaign, story, brand, whatever you're trying to do.

[00:20:18] Jody Avirgan: Now that Jesse had people's attention, he had to figure out what to do with it. He and his team began brainstorming ways to entertain the audience anytime the action slowed in a baseball game, which if you've been to a baseball game, happens a lot. If a batter was walking up to the plate, why not dance up to the plate? For a pitching change, why not drag the new pitcher in on a banana boat? Or why not have the player do the splits? Like banana splits.

[CROWD CHEERING]

[00:20:31] Baseball Announcer: The world's tallest hitter...

[00:20:51] Jesse Cole: So we have a player on stilts. So a kid, that kid, the Dakota Allbritton, showed up to practice tryout and he was an average baseball player. He wasn't gonna make the team. And he said, "I actually have my stilts." And I go, "Okay, can you hit in them?" And he said, "I never have." I go, "Well, let's try." And he gets in the batter's box on his stilts, 10 feet in the air, and starts hitting line drives. You made the team, kid.

[00:21:09] Baseball Announcer: ...and miracles do indeed happen, folks. You better believe Dakota "Stilts" Allbritton has lined his first base hit in his Bananas career.

[00:21:21] Jesse Cole: Well, we have another guy that came up to me and said, "I'd like to light my bat on fire and come up to bat." I was like, "Can you do that?" And he lit his bat on fire, came up to bat, and laced a base hit up the middle.

[00:21:31] Jody Avirgan: The Bananas try everything. And they put it all out on social media.

[00:21:37] Jesse Cole: We do 10 to 15 things every night on the field we'd ever done before.

[00:21:39] Jody Avirgan: Huh?

[00:21:39] Jesse Cole: So, so 9 to 13 of those fail miserably, like every night. And, but we're obsessed with experimentation.

[00:21:45] Jody Avirgan: So 9 of 13 fail. You only put the four that work out on social media?

[00:21:50] Jesse Cole: Oh no. We share ones that go wrong. I mean, uh, we, we do share ones because that actually people appreciate that. It's just part of our ethos is we are not in the baseball business, we're in the entertainment business.

[00:21:59] Jody Avirgan: The entertainment business, right. We don't generally think of sports this way, but this isn't exactly new. The Harlem Globetrotters and WWE took sports and turned them into pure entertainment, and even in super-traditional baseball, think about someone like PK Wrigley, who turned Wrigley Field into one of America's most beloved ballparks. He wasn't a sports guy, he was a gum guy.

And for decades, ask any long-suffering Cubs fan. He barely cared about whether the team was any good. He mostly just cared about the experience at the ballpark. Jerry Buss took the Lakers to the next level because he borrowed the idea of sexy dancers and front-row seats and splashy marketing from Hollywood. He also drafted Magic Johnson, but you get my point.

What's different with Jesse is that he knows within hours of a new idea whether it's going to be a hit or a flop. Because... it's the internet. You get feedback immediately.

[00:22:52] Jesse Cole: Because we're pumping out so much content. I mean, 10, 20 pieces a day. Even in the off-season, you start to see, obviously, what works, what doesn't.

And so our talented team is, we're filming and we're saying, "All right, ooh, that that generated, you know, 200,000 shares." We care more about shares than we do likes, comments, or views. Shares is, you know, is it remarkable? Do people wanna put their name behind it? Put themselves behind it. Is it cool enough to share? And that's how we build our whole marketing, you know, machine is that everyone we're posting things that everyone wants to share with others 'cause it's so unique, so different.

[00:23:20] Jody Avirgan: Be different. If there's one way to summarize what Jesse's doing with the Bananas, I think that's it.

[00:23:28] Jesse Cole: Our mindset on everything is whatever's normal, do the exact opposite. If you're gonna do things that are normal, you're gonna get normal results.

[00:23:34] Jody Avirgan: But again, I have to wonder, does all this attention actually translate to real-world fandom? It seems like Jesse's answer is yes; Bananas attendance has increased dramatically. There's more tickets sold throughout the season, more sellout games.

But are people coming for the baseball or the same spectacle they saw on TikTok? What exactly are they fans of? What's more, Jesse started to notice that something at the games was... missing.

[00:24:04] Jesse Cole: We were watching fans leave games early, over and over, and again, even with all the entertainment and all the fun and everything we were doing. So we said: could we develop a game that's faster, more entertaining in a two-hour time limit?

[00:24:13] Jody Avirgan: Eureka! Reinvent the very game itself. And he changed it so much that he stopped calling it baseball. Now the bananas play, you guessed it, Banana Ball.

[00:24:25] Jesse Cole: We're all in on a two-hour time game where batters can't step out of the batter's box. There's no bunting 'cause bunting sucks. You can literally steal first. If a fan catches a foul ball, it's an out. I'll tell you when it happens though, we've had it happen eight times, fans go nuts. It's one of the coolest things. There's no walks, and we're playing nine innings in an hour and 50 minutes, which a normal game is over three hours. So because of this new game we developed, we limited the traditional game that we used to play and we only do this.

[00:24:49] Jody Avirgan: Well, you know, you're hinting at it here. You know, you're almost telling me that you didn't, you don't think regular baseball is fun.

[00:24:57] Jesse Cole: Well, I, I, I will say regular baseball, what MLB is, they have the best baseball players in the world.

There's no question. And they will always be the best baseball league in the world. We're not playing that game.

[00:25:06] Jody Avirgan: Yeah.

[00:25:07] Jesse Cole: We're not gonna be the best baseball team in the world, but we're gonna be the most fun baseball.

[00:25:10] Jody Avirgan: For a few years, the Bananas would play the traditional way when they played at other stadiums. They could only play Banana Ball at home and only for certain games.

So Jesse created a spinoff team, the Party Animals, sort of like the Washington Generals to their Harlem Globetrotters. That way they can play Banana Ball against the Party Animals over and over. At the end of the 2022 season, the Bananas left their traditional league entirely and went independent. Now they don't have to play regular baseball at all.

And look, I'll say it, someone needed to push baseball to be less boring. But I do find it funny that Jesse bought a baseball team, renamed it, found new ways of marketing it to bring more people to the games, but then to keep those people in the seats, he had to change the game itself.

[00:25:54] Jesse Cole: The reality is like the, the baseball purists, which is getting smaller and smaller every single day, we're not for them. We don't need to appease them. There's so many people that don't like what we do and they hate what we do, but there's a much bigger demographic that I think people want to come out and have fun and see things they've never seen before on a baseball field.

[00:26:11] Jody Avirgan: Banana Ball is still a sport, I think, but it's closer to the intersection of sports and some sort of dance and performance art. As with Drive to Survive, the gap between storytelling and sport has basically collapsed down to zero, and Jesse's fine with that. He really doesn't see a distinction between marketing and gameplay. That's really clear when Jesse names his competition. I don't mean who the Savannah Bananas play against, I mean who he thinks he's competing with for the attention of Bananas fans.

[00:26:43] Jesse Cole: It would be Amazon, it'd be Disney, it'd be Chick-fil-A, it'd be Ritz-Carlton. It's be, it'd be against the companies that, uh, increase the expectations for the customer and the guest that put it to another level. And if, you know, you can get something shipped in an hour from Amazon, if, you know Chick-fil-A, you can go through a fast food like this and be treated well, we wanna deliver that type of experience.

[00:27:01] Jody Avirgan: Yeah. It's, it's, uh, it's funny, I, I'm just noticing you, you're very comfortable moving between saying something is a game versus a show, versus entertainment. Like, you know, it seems like it's all the same to you.

[00:27:14] Jesse Cole: Yeah, it's, it's, for us it's always, it's always a show. However, it's a different show every night, and that's what makes it interesting. The Bananas lost games to the Party Animals last year. They lost five. You know, that happens. You can go to a game. In front of 10,000 people, the Bananas lose. But that's part of what a, a great show. There's great moments in shows, and there's moments that are tough and there's challenging, and we want the show to be unique every night.

[00:27:35] Jody Avirgan: Yeah, and I mean, you know, that is why people talk about sports as sort of bulletproof in the marketplace, because at the end of the day, something's gonna get played, and you don't know how, what the outcome is and if that's just gonna keep people.

[00:27:47] Jesse Cole: Well, you want something to root for.

[00:27:47] Jody Avirgan: Yeah.

[00:27:48] Jesse Cole: Everybody wants something to root for. And I think that's what sports has. But sports has to continue to reinvent because I'll tell you, especially with baseball in a sense, we've all seen the similar highlights. We've seen a home run, we've seen a strikeout, we've seen great plays. Our guys right now are working on catching the balls doing backflips and catching the ball behind the back and doing trick pitches, throwing between the legs. Like those are the things our players are working on 'cause you've never seen them before. We want a different level of highlight.

[00:28:11] Jody Avirgan: Worth mentioning: the Bananas also have a docu-series. It's called Banana Land. It's on ESPN+. So as you can see, Jesse is doing all of it.

[00:28:21] Jesse Cole: Our merchandise numbers are through the roof. We're doing hundreds of orders every single day from all over the world. So that's drawing people in, which creates a fan. Then people see them in the shirts. That creates a conversation. "Have you seen a game?" "No, but I've watched a game on ESPN. Oh, did you see it?" And then all of a sudden it creates more conversation. Then the ultimate level is seeing a game in person. Once you see that, then you become hopefully a bigger fan, and then this flywheel continues.

[00:28:44] Jody Avirgan: The flywheel of fandom. There are a lot of places you can hop on: marketing, merchandise, media, the game itself, but they all feed into each other, and if Jesse does his job, no matter where you hop on, you're gonna keep going round and round, gaining momentum. I, of course, am a little skeptical.

Again, anything that feels like it's largely a gimmick or a marketing ploy... I don't know. I mean, how many times can you watch an umpire dance while calling strikes or someone on stilts try to bat? The skeptic in me wonders if this will last. I think about the world of digital news where I've made my home. The fate of entire companies have hinged on the fickleness of attention, the particulars of to whom and how Facebook shared your content.

Whole companies just pivoted to video and then we're left holding the bag. So, like, with one tweak of the TikTok algorithm, does all the attention on the Savannah Bananas go away?

Are we gonna see Jesse pivot to pickleball? And yet the optimist in me just knows that someone as creative as Jesse will find a way to keep one-upping himself.

[00:29:51] Jesse Cole: The future of sports is not a spectator sport. I think the idea to get fans involved in every aspect of the game, whether it is betting, whether predicting what's gonna happen, whether it's catching a foul ball, which can impact a game. Then you get fans to feel like they are truly a part of something and that gives them ownership to feel engaged in the experience.

[00:30:12] Jody Avirgan: Jesse quit playing the sports economy—like, he tossed the rule book aside, and he joined a related but decidedly different world: the attention economy. Both the bananas and Drive to Survive show how much marketing matters and maybe more than ever marketing matters the most.

We will always gather to watch sports. I believe that because we just like communal events. But I do think that in order for a sport to stay with us—not just for the next year, but for the next decade, the next generation, to have a seat at that table—something has to shift and that's something may very well force the sport itself to change.

They might be subtle, but I would not be shocked if the baseball my grandchildren enjoy doesn't look anything like the baseball that I've seen. People will have to start thinking like Jesse or Liberty Media. How do we hold your attention? Is what we're giving you better than movies and TV, better than a video game, better than a night at a nice restaurant, better than whatever else you'd be doing on a Tuesday night.

Tuesday night, though? Tuesday night Frisbee. That one's gonna stick. Seriously. Anyone listening, that's a free idea. You can have that. Just get in touch. I'll help make it happen. On the next episode of Good Sport, I've always been someone who hates to lose. Turns out there's a reason for that:

[00:31:42] Ian Robertson: You have this emotional reaction to losing, which in the brain corresponds to decline in dopamine activity in the brain's reward network. And it's actually very close to some of the pain centers of the brain, so it feels like pain.

[00:31:59] Jody Avirgan: We look at how a losing team keeps going. Good Sport is brought to you by the TED Audio Collective. It's hosted by me, Jody Avirgan. This show is produced by TED. This episode was written and produced by Poncie Rutsch. Our team includes Isabel Carter, Camille Peterson, Sarah Nics, Jimmy Gutierrez, Michelle Quint, BanBan Cheng, and Roxanne Hai Lash.

Jake Gorsky is our sound designer and mix engineer. Fact-checking for this episode by Julia Dickerson. Thanks again to Jess and Spencer. Be sure to check out their F1 podcast as well as all the great work they do. And if you're heading to a Savannah Bananas game, or you wanna buy the rights to Tuesday night Frisbee, get in touch. Our email is goodsport@ted.com. Thanks to everyone who's reached out so far. We really love hearing from you. Make sure you're following Good Sport in your favorite podcast app, so you get every episode delivered straight to your device. And while you're doing that, leave us a rating and a review.

We'll be back soon with more Good Sport. My name is Jody Avirgan. See ya soon.